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Urban Foraging and Digital Storytelling as Practices of World-Making for Social Change: A Case Study

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‘It’s a multispecies affair” (Lowenhaupt-Tsing & Haraway, 2015)

“When you build a relationship with the natural world…you start being more careful about how you move through the world and how you walk on the land” (Linda Black Elk quoted in Nelson, 2024)

“Happy snacking, don’t die!” (Alexis Nikole Nelson)

Abstract

This thesis explores the work of Alexis Nikole Nelson, aka @blackforager- as a case study on digital storytelling, ecological pedagogy and speculative World-Making within Communication for Development.

Nelson's urban foraging and digital storytelling work is deeply relational and embodied, grounded in the land, her communities, and ancestral memory. Her joyful and accessible approach to urban foraging becomes a vehicle for participatory, decolonial learning, offering alternative narratives that challenge dominant environmental discourses shaped by whiteness, settler colonialism, and extractive capitalism.

Drawing on intersecting frameworks including speculative ecofeminism, critical place-thinking, multispecies ethnography, and decolonial ecological thought, this study situates Nelson's practice within a broader ComDev context. Rather than framing development through conventional models of intervention and expertise, Nelson enacts a pedagogy rooted in reciprocity, storytelling, and sensory experience. Her digital content, which blends humour, human/botanical history, recipes, and ecological knowledge, illustrates how culturally resonant storytelling can foster inclusive ecological imaginaries and future-oriented thinking.

Nelson's work exemplifies what Arturo Escobar (2018) describes as *ontological design* within the *Pluriverse*—"a world where many worlds fit" (Zapatista quote in Escobar, 2018, p. xvi). Her storytelling reclaims space for Black and

Indigenous knowledge systems and performs a kind of joyful resistance that is deeply political, yet accessible to everyone. In a postdigital media landscape where attention is scarce, Nelson's success demonstrates the power of hybrid, non-extractive narratives that engage audiences through delight, intimacy, and love.

This thesis argues that Nelson's praxis is a form of communication for development that centres relationality, love, multispecies kin entanglements and radical possibilities. Her "digital carrier bag" of stories and plants offers more than simply content—it provides alternative ways of *being*. She is foraging, assembling and negotiating possible futures.

Keywords: Digital Storytelling, Ecofeminist Pedagogy, Speculative World-Making, Decolonial Communication, Multispecies Relationality

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Definitions

Cyborg- Traditionally, a cyborg is seen as a hybrid of organic life and technology, emphasising the physical integration of machine and body, often reflecting themes of enhancement, control, or dystopia. In Donna Haraway's (1991) Feminist/Postmodern re-definition of the term she sees the cyborg as a metaphor for breaking down boundaries between categories like human/machine, nature/culture, and male/female. Her cyborg challenges fixed identities and essentialist feminism, embracing fluidity and hybridity. It serves as a political figure resisting dominant power structures and imagining new forms of solidarity.

Joy- throughout this thesis this author uses a capitol J in Joy in order to emphasise how much Joy has been and is a necessary part of surviving, resisting and thriving.

Kin- This word is borrowed from Donna Haraway (2016) and this author uses this term to mean the ones we choose to be in relation with, walk beside and engage with. Beyond our human relatives, partners, friends and children, these are the kin of the natural world.

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1. Introduction

This time of ours has many names: the Anthropocene, Capitalocene, Plantationocene, or 'the Great[1] Dithering' (Stanley Robinson, quoted in Haraway, 2016, p. 102). Regardless of whichever title you prefer, it is beyond clear that we are living in a world of multiple global crises, ecological uncertainties and tipping points. Human Induced Climate Change (HICC) is unfolding in front of us, on our screens and in our backyards. No longer a worrying future yet to unfold, it is already affecting humans and Earth systems in unprecedented and ever-increasing ways (IPCC, 2024). Reports from the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) are finally beginning to highlight the importance of BIPOC knowledge systems in fostering sustainable practices and resilience frameworks which emphasise interconnectedness and reciprocity and challenge dominant Western narratives that have historically separated humans from nature. The constant stream of disasters related to HICC, amplified by a relentless news cycle, can often trigger anxiety and a sense of helplessness. However, involvement in local and collective environmental efforts has been shown to help ease these emotional burdens. One study found that protesting, volunteering, or simply discussing concerns with others provided an outlet for these feelings. The researchers emphasised that "action is the best antidote to climate anxiety" (Campbell, 2025, para. 7)

[1] Authors own addition

1.1 New Ways of Imagining are Needed

Foraging can be such an action. Both as a practice and a way of being, foraging in rural and urban environments enables humans to engage with nature and the beings that inhabit it in a free and accessible manner. As our urban concrete societies spread 'imperial debris' (Stoler, 2008, p. 195) across ever-diminishing wilderness, urban foraging can help us 'stay with the trouble' (Haraway, 2016) and engage with landscapes relationally and reciprocally- not as things or backdrops but as entangled active participants in a multispecies world, as a"...beloved community..." (*The King Center's Definition of Nonviolence*, no date).

Urban foraging is an invitation to engage in speculative, non-linear and embodied world-making, where knowledge is not only cognitive but also shaped by bodily interactions with landscapes, histories and ecologies. *Becoming* rather than *Doing.* Foraging has long been a fundamental practice between humans and the world in which we live. Engaging with the landscape is a form of subsistence practice, along with hunting and land management practices, which humans have engaged with for thousands of years (Graeber & Wengrow, 2021). It embodies a form of attunement to ecological rhythms, fostering relationships with both human and non-human actors. Historically, foraging has provided sustenance and informed cultural practices, belief systems, and modes of storytelling (Alger *et al.*, 2023). Storytelling and foraging are thus profoundly intertwined; both are means of navigating and making sense of the world.

In America, foraging appeals to a broad demographic of race, class, ethnicity, and geography (Arrington *et al.*, 2017) for various reasons such as connection to

nature, additional food provisioning, cultural significance and community engagement. However, complex barriers to foraging and other outdoor pursuits exist for some communities, including Indigenous and Black communities (Finney, 2014, p. 114; Arrington *et al.*, 2017). This is because foraging or, indeed, any way of being with/in/having access to nature or even the perception of nature has been shaped by race, class, and historical exclusion.

1.2 Alexis Nikole Nelson @blackforager

Alexis Nikole Nelson, also known as @blackforager, is a social media influencer and content creator who gained fame for her joyful and educational urban foraging posts during the COVID-19 pandemic. She utilises digital platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, and Bluesky to demystify the act of foraging, making it accessible to everyone. She primarily films herself foraging and cooking the edibles from her hometown of Columbus, Ohio. Although much of her content is how to forage and cook wild edibles, Nelson also uses her platform to highlight the historical and cultural dimensions of foraging and access to wilderness and nature in the US, particularly for marginalised communities historically excluded from natural spaces, as well as tell botanical narratives of the plants she encounters. Through humour, knowledge-sharing, and community-building, Nelson challenges conventional notions of who belongs in nature and reclaims foraging as an act of modern-day resistance, resilience against destruction, and a joyful practice of reciprocity. Nelson's work seems urgent as the relationship between humans and technology deepens. By telling ecological stories and teaching urban foraging online, she connects and

assembles new forms of hybrid multispecies entanglements. Imperative in our time, her work must be seen as an essential and modern environmental communication practice, at once speculative, imaginative, joyful and full of hope.

1.3 Alternative Modes of Development

Foraging, as an act of re-enchantment with place, embodies alternative modes of development. As a 'world-making' practice, it is ecofeminist in prioritising mutual care, diversity and alternative economies (Shiva, 1989). Urban foraging reclaims land from extractive economies and re-situates development as a practice of attunement, reciprocity, and mutual flourishing (Wall Kimmerer, 2015), thereby rejecting the scarcity models of food deserts, redlining zones, and urban cityscapes. Suppose development is fundamentally about creating conditions for well-being, justice, and resilience. In that case, urban foraging forms a part of a speculative world-making that imagines future(s) beyond and within collapse and ruination.[2] Such emergent forms of development do not seek to impose or dominate but instead to inquire and co-create. It is a practice of pluriversal engagement in which alternative futures can find soil and take root.

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[2] In the paper 'Imperial Debris' academic Laura Stoler (2008) uses the words 'ruination and ruin', to mean "an active process and a vibrantly violent verb...and are what people are left with: to what remains, to the aftershocks of empire, to the material and social afterlife of structures, sensibilities, and things." (Stoler, 2008, p. 194). It is a fascinating paper worth reading but wordcount limits this paper.

If urban foraging is an intervention that reclaims knowledge, space, and relationships, digital platforms can be understood as amplifiers of such practices. They can connect urban foraging to a broader audience than would be possible in person, thus enabling a form of world-making that is simultaneously situated and expansive, entangling worlds and territories into a joint story of survival and collaboration. So, rather than understanding the digital as separate from the physical, we can see that they could be co-constitutive of each other, where the online becomes dynamic sites of relationality, allowing movements to emerge and evolve across different scales and contexts and mobilise people beyond their physical geographies to challenge dominant discourses of extractive development. Alexis Nikole Nelson is a powerful example of this kind of entanglement work. She uses social media to educate and inspire a broad audience while actively dismantling the racialised exclusions embedded in traditional environmental stewardship. By centring on Black experiences and histories in the practice of urban foraging, she challenges the whiteness of mainstream American environmental movements—movements historically shaped by racism and imperialism, something which will be detailed later. In doing so, she is decolonising and democratising access to ecological knowledge and reclaiming foraging as an act of resistance, sustainability, community-building, and love in both digital and physical landscapes.

1.4 Research Question

How and in which ways can Nelson's digital storytelling and urban foraging be understood as precarious and hopeful World-Making for social change?

2. Literature review

2.1 Foraging

Foraging is the practice of searching for and gathering wild foods that grow without human cultivation. These include fruit, berries, mushrooms, herbs, seaweed, and shellfish. Fishing and hunting are also forms of foraging. It should be noted that without cultivation does not mean without human intervention. There are few places left on earth that have not in some way been impacted by human interaction. Foraging often evokes images of someone in wellies with a basket, searching forest floors or riverbanks—but it is not limited to remote or rural areas. Foraging can also be a joyful, creative, and imaginative experience. Many foragers walk miles to find Chanterelles, golden mushrooms hiding under leaf litter. Others delight and feast when stumbling on an unintended bounty of roadside blackberries. Most people will have had some foraging experience, whether planned or accidental, at some point. I have yet to meet a single person who hasn't.

2.2 Foraging Historical Background

Foraging as a relational way of being with and in nature is a prehistoric practice. Foraging formed part of a hunter-gatherer lifestyle that has sustained humans for most of our history. Identifying edible plants and tracking food sources required cooperation and problem-solving skills in the group, and scientists believe that it may have even helped shape our early human traits of social relationships, community structures and ecological stewardship (Alger *et al.*, 2023).

Around 12,000 years ago, humans underwent a mass transition from hunter-gathering to farming. The rise of agriculture and cereal production led to more settled societies, the development of land ownership, and the emergence of hierarchical societies. This development led to foraging, hunting, and seasonal nomadic 'agriculture' becoming more infrequent. Later on, commercial food production contributed to its decline (Linnekin, 2018, p. 996). However, as argued in *The Dawn of Everything*, foraging did not simply vanish with the 'rise' of 'civilisation'. Instead, historical and archaeological evidence suggests that foragers coexisted with and engaged with large-scale societies. In North America, for example, Indigenous groups, such as those in the Mississippi region, combined agriculture with seasonal foraging, while in Europe, wild food gathering persisted alongside farming for centuries. It has remained crucial to human adaptation and survival (Kopenawa & Albert, 2013; Graeber & Wengrow, 2021). Examples of hunter-gatherer societies which live alongside today's modern 'civilisations' are the Hadza people of Tanzania, San,

the Ju/'hoansi (Southern Africa – Namibia, Botswana, Angola), the Awá (Brazil, Amazon Rainforest), the Nukak (Colombia, Amazon Rainforest) and the Agta (Philippines).

2.3 Foraging in Europe

As discussed, foraging has played a crucial role in human evolution. In many countries, present-day public land access rights can be traced back hundreds of years to the foraging practices and common law from which they originated.

In Sweden, the ‘Allemansrätten’ or Everyman’s Right is an ancient ‘right to roam’ law encoded into the Swedish Constitution in 1994. It states that "everyone shall have access to nature through the right of public access" and that "everyone who uses the right of public access or otherwise stays in nature shall show consideration and caution in their interactions with it" (Bengtsson, 2018, [authors translation], p.7) Unlike other parts of Europe, where private property restricts access to land, Sweden, as well as a few other nations such as Norway, Finland and Iceland, have maintained a tradition of open access, reinforcing a cultural connection to nature which usurps landownership.

In Ireland, a set of legal codes known as the Brehon laws, which can be dated to the 7th and 8th centuries (Britannica.com, no date), granted people the legal right to gather wild food from both common and private lands under certain conditions. Invasions, colonisation, and the Industrial Revolution significantly and violently altered many people's historical rights and access to land and natural resources in Ireland.

In medieval England, the right to roam was often embedded in local laws and customs, granting access to common land to collect food from forests, fields, and waterways. In 2000, the Countryside and Rights of Way Act provided a framework for where and how to roam legally. However, foraging is generally restricted to private property without permission (Countryside and Rights of Way Act 2000).

2.4 Foraging in the US

In what is now the United States, foraging has a long and complicated history, shaped by Indigenous stewardship, violent colonial oppression, genocide and modern legal conflicts. Well before European settlers set foot on Turtle Island (the United States), Indigenous nations practised sustainable foraging as part of holistic ecological stewardship, including hunting and seasonal agriculture. They actively managed the ecosystems in which they lived by using techniques such as controlled burns, selective harvesting, and reciprocal relationships with nature, in which resources were managed to sustain future generations (Wall Kimmerer, 2015; Linnekin, 2018; Graeber & Wengrow, 2021).

With European colonisation came privatisation and restrictions on Indigenous stewardship of the land. Settlers viewed Indigenous land use as wasteful, justifying dispossession through treaties and forced removals while at the same time maintaining their right to forage, hunt, and fish (Linnekin, 2018, p.1009). Foraging diminished in importance for European settlers as agriculture expanded, but it remained critical for Afro-Indigenous and enslaved communities. Enslaved people supplemented their inadequate rations with food

they cultivated or foraged, blending African and Indigenous knowledge for survival (Elmjouie, 2022). While foraging was initially protected by law, the Civil War's end saw former enslavers, mostly in the South, enacting anti-foraging or 'no trespassing' laws to restrict Black access to land and resources, forcing them back onto plantations. "The pattern is really pronounced in the Deep South states... Eastern Tennessee—then, as now—is predominantly white. [In] Western Tennessee, there's a larger Black population there. So, what does the state legislature do? We've got one set of laws for Western Tennessee and one for Eastern Tennessee" (Linnekin quoted in *The Awful TRUTH About 'No Trespassing' Laws*, 2022, 9:57-10:17).

These laws also violently oppressed First Nations. Indigenous land-use practices, which emphasised seasonal mobility and communal ownership, conflicted with European property concepts. Using Lockean principles, settlers deemed land 'unowned' unless it was traditionally cultivated, thereby enabling forced removals. Policies such as the Indian Removal Act (1830) and rulings like Johnson v. M'Intosh (1823) legitimised Indigenous dispossession. "The history of early American anti-foraging laws reveals that supporters of restricting foraging rights typically grounded their efforts in racism, classism, colonialism, imperialism, or some combination of these odious practices and beliefs" (Linnekin, 2018, p.1011).

By the late 19th century, anti-foraging laws expanded beyond Black and Indigenous communities to also include poor rural white communities all over America. The conservation movement, led by figures like John Muir and

Theodore Roosevelt, sought to protect 'pristine wilderness,' barring subsistence foraging. For example, the Adirondack Park (1890) was established by elites who viewed local farmers as incapable of environmental stewardship in New York State and Vermont (Linnekin, 2018, p. 1114). According to Carolynn Finney's book *Black Faces, White Spaces* (2014), this exclusionary conservation model has shaped national parks and forests of the US, reinforcing an association between access to nature and whiteness. Outdoor recreation and environmentalism became middle- and upper-class white pursuits, while Black and Indigenous peoples were framed as 'Noble Savages,' their environmental knowledge ignored. These racist legacies persist today. Many state and federal laws restrict gathering under the guise of conservation, despite evidence that Indigenous foraging enhances biodiversity.

"Americans wanted to feel a natural affinity with the continent [USA], and it was Indians who could teach them such aboriginal closeness. However, in order to control the landscape, they had to destroy the original inhabitants" (Tuck & Yang, 2012, p. 8).

Meanwhile, Black and Indigenous people often feel unwelcome or unsafe in outdoor spaces due to historical and ongoing racial violence (Rowland-Shea et al., 2020). In an interview Alexis Nikole Nelson speaks to this reality, " you…just have to be very careful in public spaces when you're foraging…you will see me climbing a tree in a dress because, well, I feel people are going to be way less intimidated by this like 6ix-foot-tall Black person very close to them, doing an action they can't identify, if I look very cute, very sweet." (Durand, 2020, para.

16). Similarly, Ornithologist Drew Lanham humorously highlights these dangers in *Bird-Watching While Black* (2016)

"...you know, the essential tools for when you are out birding, you have your binoculars... your field guide... and if you're Black, you're going to need at least two forms of ID... never wear a hoodie [or camouflage]... the African-American word for camouflage is incognegro" (*Bird-Watching While Black: A Wildlife Ecologist Shares His Tips*, 2016, 00:23-00:55).

2.5 Representation and Access

BIPOC communities continue to be underrepresented in environmental sectors. A 2018 study of 2,057 U.S. NGOS found that only 14.5% engaged in diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives, with 85% of their staff being white (Taylor, 2018). Additionally, systemic racialised geographies—created by Jim Crow laws (late 1800s–1960s) and redlining (1930s–1970s)—have shaped environmental access. These policies segregated Black communities, limiting land ownership, economic mobility, and political power while relegating them to urban spaces with limited green areas and heightened exposure to pollution (Larsen et al., 2020). A 2020 Centre for American Progress report found that 74% of communities of colour live in nature-deprived regions, compared to 23% of white communities. Among those affected, 70% were also low-income (Rowland-Shea et al., 2020). While the Fair Housing Act of 1968 aimed to end housing discrimination, Black communities have continued the fight for spatial justice through movements such as community land trusts, environmental justice activism, and urban farming initiatives. Groups such as the Cooperative

Land Trust Movement and leaders like Majora Carter, who pioneered urban green space activism in the 2000s (Green The Ghetto), have worked to reclaim land and challenge the environmental racism that disproportionately places Black communities in polluted, under-resourced neighbourhoods.

"In the United States, where race is woven into the fabric of our national identity, a profound understanding of those relationships requires the willingness…to throw off the cloak of denial that keeps the "darkest aspects of America's past…hidden from plain view"…ignoring how the past has the power 'to shape the realities of our daily lives" (Finney, 2014, p. 115).

2.6 Urban Foraging

> "Urban foraging is a vibrant and important practice for many diverse communities… where human-nature relationships in cities shape heterogeneous ecologies of belonging" (Poe et al., 2014, p. 902).

Urban foraging takes place in cities, where individuals gather edible or medicinal plants from parks, sidewalks, abandoned lots, and other urban green spaces. It requires extensive knowledge of pollution risks, property laws, and city regulations and a good eye for avoiding dog pee and spotting the fresh, often-ignored food sources growing out of the pavement. Cities are often overlooked as sites for food, medicine, and material provisioning. Still, in urban

environments such as food deserts[3], foraging has been shown to contribute positively to community food security and health outcomes through access to free and more nutritionally dense food sources (Poe *et al.*, 2014, p. 104; Bellows *et al.*, 2023). Urban foraging can also be a critical knowledge-sharing activity that helps transfer cultural values and environmental stewardship (Clouse, 2022, p. 286), particularly within minority and migrant communities (Poe *et al.*, 2014).

"...[W]ho and what belongs in a specific place is not a reflection of essential nature, but rather arises from the interplay of human and more-than-human agencies with sociocultural political and ecological contingencies" (Poe *et al.*, 2014, pp. 910-914), opening up "imaginative possibilities for alternative politics grounded in ethical caring of and for 'significant otherness'" (Poe et al., 2014, p. 903). This counters dominant narratives shaped by capitalism, urban planners and property laws, raising questions about who decides how space is used, who has access to it, and whose knowledge is privileged (Poe *et al.*, 2014).

Foraging also reveals that our relationship with nature is not static but an ongoing process shaped by inhabitation. Cities become "places in the making" (Poe et al., 2014, p. 904), continually transformed through human and non-human interactions. Multispecies entanglements create relational

[3] A food desert is defined by the USDA, Treasury, and HHS as a low-income census tract where a significant number of residents have limited access to supermarkets or large grocery stores that offer healthy, affordable food. These areas typically meet criteria for both low income and low access, with over 13.5 million Americans—82% of whom live in urban areas.(Ver Ploeg, Nulph and Williams, 2011)

ecologies of belonging that recognise 'organisms' practices, their inventions, and experiments, crafting interspecies lives and worlds. Donna Haraway (2016) beautifully explains that we can understand this as

"an ecology inspired by a feminist ethic of response-ability, in which questions of species difference are always conjugated with attentions to affect, entanglement, and rupture; it is an affective ecology in which creativity and curiosity and love characterise the experimental forms of life of all kinds of practitioners, not only the humans." (Haraway, 2016, p. 68). It becomes a multispecies entanglement, an ever-unravelling story honouring ancestral knowledge transmission (Kopenawa & Albert, 2013; Wall Kimmerer, 2015; Graeber & Wengrow, 2021). Many Indigenous stories from the United States, such as The Three Sisters[4] (Haudenosaunee), The Salmon People (Coast Salish, Tlingit, and Haida communities) and wild rice harvesting or 'Manoomin' (Anishinaabe) highlight themes of reciprocity, creation, and the interconnectedness of all life, emphasising deep respect for nature and the balance between humans and the Earth (Wall Kimmerer, 2015).

However, foraging is also contested as a practice, as overforaging can disturb or deplete natural resources. In Vermont, the annual Fiddlehead (Ostrich Fern tips) and Ramps (Wild Leek) season is met with equal amounts of excitement and concern. Excessive harvesting has caused a decline in population (VT Fish &

[4] The Three Sisters are a traditional planting method practiced by many Indigenous Peoples of Turtle Island. It honours Corn, Squash and Bean as living relatives and vital participants in sustaining life and reflects a deep cultural understanding of interdependence, gratitude, and the continuous creation cycle rooted in the creation story. (White, 2019)

Wildlife, 2021), leading to anger and resentment towards immigrant communities and a younger generation considered not skilled or knowledgeable enough to forage sustainably. This is a problem facing many areas in the US, particularly since the COVID-19 pandemic, when foraging gained in popularity (Clouse, 2022). The Global pandemic revealed the fragility of North America's food system. It led to people needing to supplement their diets through food banks, community outreach projects, and practices such as gleaning and foraging. COVID-19 also impacted how people behaved, as restrictions on movement led to increased time spent outside and a surge in gardening activities (McLain *et al.*, 2014; Poe *et al.*, 2014; Shortly and Kepe, 2021; Clouse, 2022; Bellows *et al.*, 2023).

Much research is being conducted on urban planning to support urban foraging and mitigate the issue of overharvesting by incorporating community forests and gardens in towns and cities across America (Poe et al., 2014; Shortly and Kepe, 2021; Clouse, 2022; Bellows et al., 2023). However, being a forager, regardless of where one forages, can be confusing because restrictions vary from state to state. In New York, for example, it is a "common interpretation of the ordinance that foraging is against the law…[with fines]..up to $250 [but in most cases the city] opted in favour of education…over fines" (Linnekin, 2018, p. 1016). In state parks and on federal land, polices tend to favour conservation, so although the public is encouraged to use and enjoy the outdoors, there are strict rules on what you can do, what you can pick and how much. This has historically impacted Indigenous communities harder as their traditional

foodways have been restricted and violently oppressed in favour of North American 'conservation'.[5]

Despite historical and legal barriers, foraging is experiencing a resurgence as communities reclaim their rights and access to natural resources. Laws and policies are gradually changing to accommodate Indigenous land practices (Linnekin, 2018; Rush, 2024). Indigenous nations, such as the Salish, fight for treaty-recognised harvesting rights, while urban foragers challenge anti-foraging laws, pressuring governments to recognise foraging's cultural and ecological significance. In 2022, Cabot, Vermont, became the state's first municipality to grant Indigenous people the right to forage on public lands.

"If you're acknowledging that we're on the unceded territory of the Abenaki, then you should give us land access so we can continue to gather our nuts, foods, and medicines" (Chief of the Nulhegan Band of the Coosuk-Abenaki Nation interviewed, Edgar, 2022, para. 7).

It seems that despite the entangled histories of colonisation, exclusion, and environmental injustice, communities persist in reclaiming foraging—not just as a survival strategy but as a decolonial act, an ecofeminist practice, and a form of ecological stewardship that resists capitalist and colonial oppression. It

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[5] North American conservation has roots in settler colonialism, often prioritising wilderness preservation through the removal or genocide of Indigenous peoples. Figures like John Muir and Theodore Roosevelt promoted conservation ideals tied to racial hierarchies, while early national parks were established by displacing Native communities, reinforcing a vision of nature as pristine only when emptied of its original stewards. For a finely written account please read Caroline Finney's book Black Faces, White Spaces, see bibiliography for more.

continues to be a Story of multispecies love and care. Foraging as an act is a way to imagine and speculate in world-making.

2.7 Storytelling

Storytelling is one of the oldest and most essential forms of human communication, and the ability to craft and share stories is a fundamental aspect of being human (Garcia-Pelegrin, Wilkins and Clayton, 2021). Not only entertainment prior to the invention of Netflix, storytelling was/is a vital knowledge-sharing act which functions as a form of pedagogy. Through gestures, tones, and structured narratives, stories transmit ecological, social, and moral knowledge in ways that are memorable and applicable, ensuring cultural continuity across generations (Scalise Sugiyama, 2017; Garcia-Pelegriñ, Wilkins, and Clayton, 2021; Graeber & Wengrow, 2021).

2.8 Historical Background

Historically, stories have bound people to land and laws. In Australia, Aboriginal songlines served as oral maps and spiritual pathways, encoding geographic, ancestral, and cosmological knowledge. Similarly, Polynesian Wayfinders used chants and shells to navigate across oceans, and Inuit hunting bands relied on scent and auditory memory to traverse icy landscapes. (Fernandez-Velasco and Spiers, 2024, p. 56). Through songs, chants, and sensorial perception, memory as story is not archived but rather embodied, place-making, culture shaping and "in a continued state of againness" (Assmann, 2008, p. 105). It is rooted in past experiences but crafted with the

future in mind (Garcia-Pelegrin, Wilkins & Clayton, 2021), becoming a temporal framework that transcends the individual life span [and participates] in extended horizons of meaning-production. " (Assmann, 2008, p. 97). Stories are thus relational acts in which people can obtain "a sense of agency, voice and belonging (Jackson, 2002, p. 185) within larger narratives. Helping humans navigate complexity, weave relationships and imagine possible futures. However, stories have also been used to oppress and dominate. As described earlier, colonial narratives framed Indigenous peoples as 'savages' in order to justify conquest and genocide. Similarly, religious and national myths have often excluded or vilified marginalised groups to sustain systems of domination such as patriarchy, racism, and imperialism. By controlling which stories are told—and who gets to tell them—elites have shaped history, identity, and values in ways that legitimise their authority. Aleida Assmann (2008) notes that memory is selective; dominant cultures institutionalise their versions of the past while silencing others. Storytelling, then, is not neutral, but can be both a form of oppression and a form of resistance.

2.9 Joy as Resistance

Black oral traditions emerge from a long history of resistance, survival, and joy-making in the face of systemic oppression. Storytelling has been a crucial space for Black communities to "name the unnameable" and reclaim agency in a world structured by white supremacy.

"Oppressed people resist by identifying themselves as subjects, by defining their reality, shaping their new identity, naming their history, telling their story." (Bell Hooks, quoted in Amoah, 2013, p. 84).

Oral culture, such as songs, folktales, sermons, and conversations across dinner tables, was an alternative way for enslaved Africans to transmit knowledge, affirm their identity, and nurture collective memory. Denied access to literacy and institutional forms of knowing, these traditions were both pedagogical and subversive. They encoded histories, cosmologies, and survival strategies and cultivated resistance beneath the surface of metaphor, rhythm, and humour (Hill Collins, 2000; Amoah, 2013; Lu & Steele, 2019). Contemporary Black storytelling continues this lineage, now also through digital platforms. Scholars such as Catherine Knight Steele and Ruha Benjamin highlight how Black women, in particular, utilise online spaces to rearticulate cultural memory, resist algorithmic bias, and forge community. In their article *Joy is Resistance* (Lu & Steele, 2019), the authors investigate how Joy is used as a political act in and of itself. Black stories of pleasure, creativity and love as told through digital technologies "facilitate the extension of pre-existing (survival) strategies like song, storytelling and signifying" (Lu & Steele, 2019, p. 826).

Across marginalised communities, joy and comedy have long served as tools of resistance. Speaking of the queeer community they are part of, Alok Vaid-Menon highlights laughter as a space of freedom and survival. In a recent interview on The Daily Show, they explained,

"...if you spend a couple of centuries surviving attempted eradication, you get kind of bored with being depressed. It's just a major buzz kill, you know. So then you...start like cracking jokes or whatever to survive...[What is] profoundly rebellious when you're a marginalised person is recognising that people might have the ability to take your rights, they might have the ability to take away your safety, but they can't take away your joy. And so what humour has become, for me is a practice of resistance..." (@alokvmenon, 2025).

In both cases, Joy becomes a deliberate act of defiance, transforming digital spaces into sites of resilience, creativity, and liberation.

2.10 Bag Ladies

A study by Brent et al. (2015) revealed that post-reproductive female killer whales serve as leaders within their pods, guiding their family to foraging grounds in times of scarcity. Having accumulated a lifetime of ecological knowledge, the survival strategy of these older females shifts from reproduction to group preservation. They became wisdom keepers, teachers, and wayfarers, utilising their accumulated life knowledge and skills, passed down matrilineally to ensure the family's survival (Brent *et al.*, 2015). The role of these elder female Orcas challenges traditional views of power and survival. In patriarchal narratives, strength, aggression, and direct competition often define success. However, the Orca matriarch demonstrates another model based on knowledge, cooperation, and intergenerational care. Her leadership is rooted not in dominance but in experience. She knows where the salmon runs and how the

tides shift. She has the maps of survival inscribed into her DNA. This mirrors how much traditional knowledge has been passed down through generations in human societies, both among men and women. Across cultures, women Elders have historically played a critical role in food gathering, medicinal plant identification, and sustainable resource use (Shiva, 1989; Thaker & Vaksibhai, 2025). They have been the keepers of ecological wisdom, ensuring the survival of their communities through stories, practice, and careful teaching. However, in many societies, these contributions have been overlooked, undervalued or violently oppressed in favour of male-dominated narratives of hunting and conquest (Sharp, 1986; Shiva, 1989; Wall Kimmerer, 2015; Thaker & Vaksibhai, 2025).

“We talk for our hunting business, ceremony business. We used to go hunting, we can’t wait for the men. We are ladies, we go hunting and feed the men too …” (Bird Rose, 1996, p. 37). In her “Carrier Bag of Fiction" theory, the visionary sci-fi writer Ursula Le Guin presents a view of storytelling rooted in gathering and sharing rather than conquest and domination. The original story is female, not male.

“…the first cultural device was probably a recipient.. a container to hold gathered products…long before the weapon, a late, luxurious, superfluous tool…” (Le Guin, 1989, pp. 167–168). Rather than the “Story of the Ascent of Man” with their “bashing, sticking, thrusting… the Killer Story”,

Le Guin revels in the notion of "the Life Story" that the container is full of the sacred, the beautiful, the nourishing.

"People have been telling the life story for ages, in all sorts of words and ways. Myths of creation and transformation, trickster stories…" (Le Guin, 1989, p. 169). For Le Guin, Science Fiction can avoid the "linear, progressive, Time's(killing)-arrow mode of the Techno-Heroic…[if one understands]…science and technology as primarily cultural carrier bag[s] rather than weapon[s] of domination"(Le Guin, 1989, p. 170).

2.11 Digital Storytelling

Over the last four decades, the internet has played an increasingly important role in amplifying awareness of ecological issues and gathering public support for environmental movements (Cornelio, Martorell & Ardèvol, 2024). Digital platforms enhance communication, coordination, and identity formation within social movements (Cornelio, Martorell & Ardèvol, 2024) and this added "digital dimension…[enables us to] reconceptualize [our] sense of space" adding "hybrid" to the "physical" and "digital" dynamic relationship between individuals and their environment (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 1). In the same way, Storytelling brings private experiences into the public realm, and digital communication allows for a series of articulations that weave personal practice into a shared human consciousness. The stories shared between us

"posse[ss] a 'spatial syntax'..[because they] encode the correct itineraries and protocols governing movement within a social environment [as well as] provide

delinquent and tactical clues as to how boundaries may be infringed…" (Jackson, 2002, p. 32).

Recent scholarship has shown the shift from large-scale protests to lifestyle-based, everyday activism, where individuals act as engines for social change through small, continuous actions. Concepts such as 'implicit activism' and 'subactivism' frame these acts as personal, low-key, and often hidden within daily life (Cornelio, Martorell and Ardèvol, 2024). These forms of 'personalised politics', which foster 'networked collective action', challenge traditional distinctions between private and public action, positioning political agency within intimate, habitual, and often subtle acts (Cornelio, Martorell and Ardèvol, 2024).

However, we must proceed with care, recognising that space and place are not passive containers but active sites of power and contestation. Not only must we be aware of the market forces implicit in the design and execution of the technologies used, but it is also important to recognise that online activism might not have the dramatic impact we expect or want.

"…[S]ocial media reinforce[s]…the weak-tie character of modern social movements….[creating] more informed but increasingly inefficient social movements" (Malcolm Gladwell quoted in Hafez and Grüne, 2022, p. 48).

An increase in coverage also leads to misinformation, 'fake news', 'post truths' and 'climate denial' particularly in the US (IPCC, 2022, paras 13–32) leading to a

tendency for "cheap talk" (Hafez & Grüne, 2022, p. 152) rather than actual change.

The digital can offer additional possibilities for resistance and reimagining beyond the historical and racialised constraints of the physical realm. The online mobilisation of real-life landscapes can reconnect communities with ecological knowledge, fostering new relational modes of living and belonging; hybrid spaces through the "joint construction of the physical sense of place and the digital sense of place [that are] intertwined and influence each other."(Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 4) where digital Storytelling becomes a form of hybrid embodied place-making. Taking Le Guin's ideas beyond the pages of the fictional novel, digital storytelling unfolds as a virtual vessel in which environmental stories of the sacred, the beautiful, and the nourishing can be told, shared and engaged with. Timeless practices, storytelling and foraging, entwined through eternity, gathered into the carrier bags of the digital forager.

2.12 Connecting Digital Storytelling and Urban Foraging

As we have seen, both foraging and storytelling are ancient, embodied practices rooted in relationships with time, space, place, and other kin. Foraging is not just about knowing where to find nourishment—it is about how that knowledge is passed down. A group's survival depends on this transmission in Orca societies and human cultures. Throughout human history, these 'maps of survival' were rarely taught through direct instruction; they were woven into narratives, myths, and oral traditions (Wall Kimmerer, 2015).

"...by telling the stories, the Elders and our parents were able to pass on their knowledge and the knowledge of our ancestors" (Gwich'in Elder Mary Kendi, quoted in Scalise Sugiyama, 2017, p.7).

While foraging teaches attunement to place, season, and reciprocity, storytelling carries memory, ethics, and meaning across generations. Both are practices of joy and creativity.

In today's digital world, these practices are not lost, but transformed[6]. The internet becomes a digital bridge, where Storytellers and foragers, new and old, can share the stories they have collected, carried and remembered with others. New ways of relating become possible when we move across planes; the physical and the virtual blur into each other, creating hybrid assemblages of space, place and relations. Édouard Glissant longs for a defining name in Storytelling for this "uninterrupted process of revelation: of putting into relation...this bringing together when it astounds us and deflects us from convention" (Glissant, 2000, p. 200) (... Never one without the other...Every poetics is a palliative for eternity" (Glissant, É., 2000, p.184). Perhaps the word/process he is looking for is foraging. Maybe the vessel is the digital.

3. Theoretical Framework

This thesis speculates with a wide constellation of thinkers and theories. It draws on ecological, feminist, decolonial and pedagogical frameworks to

[6]The internet transforms foraging by extending knowledge beyond physical walks and books, enabling broader, more accessible, and collaborative ways of learning.

explore the digital storytelling and ecological praxis of Alexis Nikole Nelson/ *@BlackForager*. Her intersectional work emerges from the cross-fertilisation and entanglement of digital culture, ancestral knowledge, ecological love, Joy and public education.

3.1 Speculative Ecofeminism

The base of this thesis is *Speculative Ecofeminism*, thinking with formidable humans such as Ursula Le Guin, Donna Haraway, and Robin Wall Kimmerer. These theorists value non-linear, embodied, and relational knowledge systems that centre more-than-human kinship, stories, reciprocity, and love. Nelson's work of entangled knowing aligns well with their feminist science (fiction) imaginaries.

The author wants to clarify that the term *"speculative"* is not the same as "guesswork." Instead, it refers to a mode of thinking and storytelling that opens up new possibilities, particularly those that are not yet fully realised or understood. It is a process of thinking *with*, a fluid, organic way of being that allows for new openings / new imaginaries. *Speculative* is understood in this study as being "experiments with the not-yet…curations of occasions through which new futures may take shape…" (Coleman & Jungnickel, 2024). These World-Making practices focus in particular on the work/play/imaginings of historically excluded peoples in order to resist additives model of exclusion- where marginalised voices are added *onto* existing structures and instead *aligns with* — Sasha Costanza-Chocks' (2020) idea of design justice: practices led by

those most affected by structural inequality, through which many worlds are collectively imagined, shaped, and built (Costanza-Chock, 2020).

3.2 Multispecies Ethnography and Critical Place-Thinking

The thesis will also draw on *Multispecies Ethnography* and *Critical Place-Thinking* and thinkers such as Anna Tsing, Eve Tuck, Laura Ann Stoler and Leanne Betasamosake Simpson to understand how place and knowledge are created. *Multispecies Ethnography* is an anthropological approach that expands the field of inquiry beyond the human to consider the agency and entanglements of more-than-human life. Grounded in feminist and posthumanist theory, it highlights how these beings co-create social worlds with humans, particularly within damaged or "contaminated" landscapes (Tsing, 2015). *Critical Place-Thinking* complements this by centring land as a living, storied being. Emerging from Indigenous epistemologies, it challenges Western notions of place as inert or abstract, asserting instead that place holds memory, power, and responsibility. Thinkers such as Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, Alice Walker and Eve Tuck frame knowledge as deeply situated and relational, requiring ethical accountability to land and community.

"Land doesn't belong to *people*. Perhaps it would be better to say the *people* belong to the land. Alternatively, perhaps, even better still, we might say that processes of continuous creation redo land, people, life and the spiritual world altogether, and in specific locations " (John Law quoted in Escobar, 2018, p. 86). Nelson's work produces life, Joy and possibility out of the contaminated

landscapes through which she roams, invigorating ecologies of multispecies entanglements, not as wilderness fantasies but as viable forms of engagement.

3.3 Decolonial Ecological Thought

These frameworks are all grounded in *Decolonial Ecological Thought* and align with the 'Design Ontologies' of the Pluriverse: "a world where many worlds fit" (Zapatista quote in Escobar, 2018, p. xvi). *Decolonial Ecological Thought* is an interdisciplinary framework that critiques dominant Western paradigms of nature, knowledge, and development rooted in colonialism and capitalism. It emphasises the importance of Indigenous and marginalised epistemologies that sustain reciprocal relationships with the land and more-than-human beings. The concept of the *Pluriverse* challenges the idea of a singular, universal truth by affirming diverse ways of being and knowing. Arturo Escobar (2018) introduces the concept of Design ontologies in relation to the Pluriverse when he argues that the dominant Western ontology we live in, which prioritises control, appropriation, extraction and separates humans from nature, is mainly a design problem.

The systems and societies that we inhabit have all been created through design. To think our way out of this extractive, destructive paradigm, we need what he calls transitions of culture in which relationality, interdependence and plurality are emphasised. For Escobar, design becomes a tool for enacting alternative

development ideas[7]. (Escobar, 2018). Nelson's work is Ontological Design because her work "nourishes difference" (Escobar, 2018, p. xvi) in the blurred landscape which is the Postdigital, a world where virtual and real are fluid states, constantly interacting with each other in more and more "complex ways" (Jandrić, 2022, pp. xiii–xiv). Through her digital presence, Nelson invites her followers to participate and engage in embodied, place-based learning through their screens, where she shares alternative ways of eating, being and inhabiting space. The joyful and material practice of foraging intersects/intermingles with visual storytelling and causes ruptures and tears in mainstream environmental narratives, which have centred the white, imperial body for centuries (Finney, 2014; Wall Kimmerer, 2015; Gravalese, 2021).

By embracing the principles of speculative world-making, participatory communication, and decolonial ecological thought, it becomes possible to envision future development initiatives that more effectively address the interconnectedness of all beings and all worlds. It can promote a more inclusive, equitable, and just world. As digital media increasingly shapes our global communication landscapes, it is crucial that development scholars and practitioners take seriously the potential of social media to engage diverse

[7] Arturo Escobar's concept of design ontologies critiques Western modernist design for its singular focus on control, efficiency, and anthropocentrism, arguing instead that all design is rooted in deeper, often unexamined worldviews—an idea that, while newly framed by Escobar, echoes older, relational ways of being. Animism embodies one such ancestral ontology, offering a living, place-based alternative that aligns with the idea of the Pluriverse by centering reciprocity, more-than-human agency, and co-creation.

audiences in speculative, decolonial, and participatory processes of ecological change which reflect a wider range of voices, experiences, and worldviews.

4. Methodology

This thesis employs a qualitative, interpretive analysis, using Alexis Nikole Nelson's account (@blackforager) as a case study to explore how digital storytelling and urban foraging can be understood as a speculative world-making praxis. Nelson's work is chosen for its richness and as a paradigmatic example of digital decolonial ecofeminist imaginative praxis, offering an exemplary manifestation of the theoretical intersections that form the beating heart of this study.

A case study methodology was selected for its ability to support in-depth, contextual analysis of a single, bounded case (Flyvbjerg, 2011). The study takes a multimodal approach, incorporating verbal, visual, auditory, and non-verbal narratives in Nelson's media content. Drawing on Chepinchikj and Thompson (2016), this method encompasses the layers of meaning that emerge from posture, language, camera work, sound, and editing —modalities that extend beyond what written text alone can convey. By focusing on representational strategies within Nelson's digital content, this study explores how her practices communicate alternative ecological futures, reclaim ancestral knowledge, and reconfigure human–nonhuman relationships in both digital and place-based contexts.

4.1 Data Collection

Primary data consists of 15 publicly accessible video posts by Nelson, varying in length between 1.44 minutes and 25 minutes, and purposively selected from her social media platforms between 2021 and 2025. The samples were chosen to reflect diversity in:

- Thematic focus (e.g., foraging, food preparation, land history)
- Geographical settings (e.g., urban forests, backyards, parks, kitchens)
- Species engagement (plants, fungi, insects, humans)
- Narrative or affective tone (pedagogic, reflective, joyful)

Each video was archived through screenshots, transcripts, and audiovisual annotations. In addition, secondary materials—including interviews, public talks, articles, and a comprehensive review of Nelson's social media content—were collected to provide contextual depth, which can be found in the Appendices.

4.2 Analytical Framework

The primary method will be a close media analysis of Nelson's digital content, specifically her social media posts, focusing on content, positionality, and visual strategies across accounts. The study aims to elucidate how Nelson's online persona and work challenge dominant cultural narratives of environmentalism, institutionalised knowledge, and belonging, and how they disrupt the historically white, male, and settler-colonial framings of nature and ecological knowledge by foregrounding Black and Indigenous epistemologies, everyday joy, and embodied experience. By doing this, this study affirms that Nelson is offering radically new ways of understanding, reading, and *being* in the world to her followers, speculating in possible worlds that are hybrid, entangled, beautiful, and accessible.

The analysis was conducted in two stages: 1. Thematic coding and 2. Critical interpretation through intersecting theoretical lenses.

1. Thematic Coding

The data was analysed to find key themes in Nelson's work, including ancestral and Indigenous Knowledge, More-Than-Human Agency, Joy and Vulnerability, Urban Ecology, Care and Futurity, Aesthetic World-Making, and Food as Pedagogy.

2. Critical Interpretation

Each video was then interpreted through the following theoretical frameworks:

- Speculative Ecofeminism – to explore how Nelson constructs future-oriented, feminist ecological imaginaries filled with Joy, imagination and community.

- Multispecies Ethnography – to examine how plants, fungi, and landscapes are storied as kin.

- Critical Place-Thinking – to trace how land, place, and colonial histories shape her storytelling and foraging practices.

- Decolonial Ecological Thought – to assess her resistance to dominant food systems and reclamation of Black and Indigenous ecological knowledge.

- Design Ontologies – to understand how her content as well the properties of her videos (sound design, editing, aesthetics) contribute to alternative ways of knowing and being.

4.3 Positionality

As a researcher, I am aware of my positionality. My interest in foraging, storytelling, and alternative ways of living/knowing/being drew me to @blackforager long before any thesis was conjured up. I am a white, northern European woman, and I continually try to hold in my mind the structural privileges I hold. I am also aware that there is a fine line between respecting

and admiring someone's work and appropriating and romanticising knowledge systems that are not my own. I try to navigate these as best I can through a commitment to a feminist and decolonial methodology, which foregrounds relational ethics, reflexivity, and accountability. Special care was taken in navigating the ethics of working with digital content. This thesis seeks not to extract from Nelson's work but to engage with it as a form of world-making, with gratitude and ethical responsibility.

4.4 Scope of Study

This thesis is a small-scale, speculative, and exploratory study that seeks to understand, in some small way, how urban foraging and digital storytelling can be a form of messy, future-imagining world-making process. As previously mentioned in the framework section, *speculative* refers to a way of thinking *with* rather than *on.* It does not imply a study built upon guesswork or imagined conclusions. It refers to the inquisitive nature of feral ideas, rooted in imagination and wisdom, and how creative thinking opens up new dimensions. It refers to the foraging nature of the human mind in making sense of stories within this world and others.

The study's limitations include its reliance on publicly available media content, its narrow focus on one central figure, and the evolving nature of digital platforms. However, the specificity of the case is also its strength, offering a vivid and Joyful example of speculative World-Making practice in the Pluriverse.

5. Case Study: @blackforager and Speculative World-Making

“Happy Snacking, Don’t Die!” -Alexis Nikole Nelson

Alexis Nikole Nelson, also known as @blackforager, gained fame during the COVID-19 pandemic when her urban foraging tips went viral. Nelson encouraged people to find edible plants around them instead of relying on stores. “a little afraid of going to the grocery store right now? That's OK! Im going to show you some things that are growing in your neighboorhood that you can eat…” (*The Awful TRUTH About ‘No Trespassing’ Laws*, 2022). Although she had been active on TikTok and Instagram before the pandemic, the lockdown skyrocketed her popularity. As of May 2025, she has over 6.6 million followers across all her platforms.







(Screenshots from Alexis Nikole Nelson's (@blackforager) Instagram account. Posted from left to right 28/04/2024, 09/05/2025, 07/05/2025 URL: https://www.instagram.com/blackforager/#)

With her tagline, "Happy Snacking, Don't Die," Nelson has sparked national interest in foraging—a niche hobby in the U.S. compared to northern Europe, where foraging is more prevalent in Scandinavian culture (Sténs & Sandström, 2014). Based in Columbus, Ohio, she hosts local foraging walks and travels widely to speak and teach. Her influence has earned her recognition as a National Geographic 2025 visionary, as well as spots on Forbes' 30 Under 30 (2022) and Fortune's Creator 25 (2021), along with awards and Ted.com talks. Through her engaging style and content, Nelson helps people reconnect with nature and themselves.

5.1 Grounding

Nelson's work is deeply rooted in her family history. She credits her mother and grandmother as key influences, recalling how her mother introduced her to Onion Grass—her first forageable plant—sparking a sense of wonder about the natural world. When choosing her online identity, Nelson realised how few foragers of colour had visible platforms. "I wanted to make sure that people knew…that those photos, that knowledge, those recipes were coming from someone Black," she said, noting the disconnect many in her community feel

from nature. “We believe that the outdoors…isn’t for us.” (CIIS, 2024). In *Black Faces, White Spaces*, Finney (2014) explains;

“[G]eographers have addressed issues of exclusion, marginality and space, particularly how images of groups and places can combine to create ‘landscapes of exclusion’ [and in particular] how key sites of ‘nationalistic sentiment’ such as the countryside implicitly excluded black people. Investigation on racial discourse within geography has explored the mutual constitution of race, space and place, the construction of the Other, and the power of racialization processes to shape environmental interactions.” (Finney, 2014, p. 7).

Talking about blackness or historic (and current) racism on her platforms is not always received well. Occasionally, Nelson will post trolls and their comments on her platforms to show the criticism and hate she receives for just showing up as a black woman in foraging communities. In a video entitled “HE’S MAD I CALL MYSELF ‘BLACK FORAGER’ 🙃”(Nelson, 2021), Nelson responds to a comment from a fellow forager who resents her for bringing race into the foraging space. “We need to talk about how none of our food, wild, grocery store… exists without context…to say that foraged food exists without any relation to race or culture… is disrespectful…everything that you eat has a story that you are the final chapter of…” (Nelson, 2021).

5.2 The Significance of Nelson's Work.

"We are embedded and enmeshed within the stories and story structures we have created, and which have been created around us, some we are aware of and some we are not…constant repeating and refashioning of life stories is an essential part of living with their complexity and fluidity, but can be uncritical." (Bolton, 2006, p. 206).

Nelson's presence in a space historically dominated by white narratives, white voices, and white power creates room for more inclusive conversations about the natural world, who is included in it/who gets to take part/and who gets to imagine and create futures. This is not only about visibility. This is about HOW knowledge is created, shared and understood.

5.3 Nelson's work as a Speculative EcoFeminist Project

"It matters what matters we use to think other matters with…It matters what stories make worlds, what worlds make stories." (Haraway, 2013, p. 4).

Speculative world-making, as inspired by Donna Haraway's concept of *Sf*—science fiction, speculative fabulation, string figures, and science fact —is a practice that embraces complexity and imagines futures rooted in hybrid relationality, care, and embodied knowledge (Haraway, 2013). Alexis Nikole Nelson's work offers a vivid, living example of this approach. In the TikTok episode *"Place Yer Bets"* (Nelson, 2024f), she invites her audience to go on a bike

ride with her to showcase the abundance of functional plants in the city. Weaving through Columbus, Ohio, with her camera tucked into her bra, Nelson bikes from her house to the local pool, stopping at each edible or medicinal encounter. The video racks up a whopping 15 plants, which she describes with great gusto and singing (yes, she does this a lot) in just over 3 minutes.



Timecodes left to right: 00:23, 01:02, 01:44, 02:38

(Screenshots from Nelsons TikTok account @alexisnikole,
Episode “Place Yer Bets”, 29/07/2024,
URL:
https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisnikole/video/7397096964308880683?lang=en)

Through her joyful and educational foraging content, Nelson reclaims ancestral knowledge; *St John's Wort is good for depression, but also acts like a birth control (so be careful) (timecode:* 2:45-2:51) She reshapes human relationships with land and food; *we learn that Stinky Bradford Pears make good cider*, *(timecode: 00:27-00:37)* and she models ecological intimacy that resists extractive systems; *Nelson teaches us that Plantain is really good medicinally as well as a replacement for chia seeds in cooking (timecode: 00:13-00:17* (Nelson, 2024f). Her practice becomes a form of speculative fabulation—not through science fiction, but through

everyday acts—offering glimpses of possible worlds grounded in reciprocity and historically marginalised, forgotten or lost environmental traditions. Like Haraway, Nelson demonstrates that world-making is never neutral; it is a situated, ethical process of imagining with others, including both humans and nonhumans. It is also Joyful. Throughout the video, Nelson makes up songs with lyrics such as: "My phone is in my bikini top, I really hope it doesn't fall", and "those pine trees are edible, I'm trying to aim my chest at them". She is wearing a bright pink dress and Princess Leia hairbuns and films herself smiling and sweaty as she gets lost, appreciates Columbus' investment in "bird shacks", but notes with a wink to the camera, "Columbus the city, not the colonizer" (Nelson, 2024f).

In her videos, Nelson blends ecological awareness with feminist critique, using storytelling to envision just, sustainable alternatives to systems of domination. It challenges human exceptionalism, centres multispecies entanglements, and foregrounds place-based, embodied knowledge. Black and queer speculative traditions expand this further, showing how future possibilities are seeded in present acts of survival and resistance—refusing linear progress narratives and addressing the interwoven struggles against colonialism, racism, and patriarchy (Coleman & Jungnickel, 2024). Together, these perspectives frame world-building as both resistance and regenerative work across human and nonhuman communities. Nelson's urban foraging and digital storytelling embody the ethos of speculative ecofeminism. Her work foregrounds relational knowledge and "becoming-with" the more-than-human world. By practising foraging in urban spaces, she disrupts anthropocentric and extractive logics,

cultivating an ethic of care, attentiveness, and connection in overlooked environments.

5.4 Interactive Communities

Nelson's encounters with edible plants and mushrooms are shared through digital mediums, and she invites and engages her audience in intimate, sensory explorations of urban ecosystems. The 'Place Yet Bets' (2024b) video has a whopping 536 comments, many of which are from people expressing how her content makes them see and act differently; "You can eat Honey locust?! I've got a volunteer sprouting in my backyard and I'm deffo gonna be munching on that!"/ "I keep chanting, I refuse to be a forager - but then I can't stop watching these videos! OK, Mulberry Leaf tea sounds unavoidable."/ "AAAA I DIDN'T KNOW FOXTAIL WAS EDIBLE. I have almost too much of it in my garden and i didn't know what to do with it, but i do now!". (Viewer comments, Nelson, 2024e)

At the same time, she trusts her viewers in their ability to accept the complexities that come with such becoming-with, and for them to step back from a solely human-centred perspective. Her practice of foraging and storytelling connects human and non-human entities in a mutual process of co-creation, where Nelson, the plants she forages and her audience all respond to and change each other. In a video titled "The Awful Truth About No Trespass" (2022), Alexis and co-host Yara Elmjouie have been out foraging for food and are back in Alexis' kitchen preparing the food. [Yara in an excited tone]

"This is amazing! We just found all this food in the wild!" [Alexis] Foraging and being more connected to place, to your present, to your past, by means of food...it's magical" [Yara speaking over shots of them eating the food] "everything we were eating, we'd gathered that day in the wild, for free. From a park, from a forest, and yes even a sidewalk..[and it was] what all this meant and the context we were doing it in. [Alexis] for me to do this act [foraging] and have no one besides me benefiting from it, it just feels like giving a middle finger to this system that was inherently created to put us at a disadvantage...in that way, foraging as a Black person is an act of rebellion". (*The Awful TRUTH About 'No Trespassing' Laws*, 2022, Timecode: 18:37-19:48).



(Screenshots from the short film *The Awful Truth About No Trespassing,*

Elmjouie & Nelson, +AJ, 15/03/2022,

URL: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Pdatu1OZbIs)

As we get to know the plants, the more-than-human-kin in our environment, our shared history and journey, can we ever really view them the same way again? Can these plant kin ever be *just* weeds again? Or is Nelson encouraging a higher level of empathy and *being with* which could be helpful for us to carry with us as we walk through uncertain times? "Visionary feminism offers us hope for the future. By emphasising an ethics of mutuality and interdependency, feminist thinking offers us a way to end domination while simultaneously changing the impact of inequity" (Hooks quoted, in Coleman and Jungnickel, 2024, p.1). She also helps us resist the commodification of nature and celebrates human-non-human entanglements by emphasising interactions between herself, the land, and her audience. The knowledge she shares is relational and embodied rather than purely intellectual. Her digital storytelling abilities blur the physical and digital realms, aligning with Haraway's concept of 'becoming-with'; instead of viewing species as separate, autonomous entities, beings emerge through relationships and community, which Nelson's work constantly affirms and emphasises (Haraway, 2016, p. 55).

5.5 @blackforagers Decolonial Ecological Work

Nelson's storytelling is disarmingly joyful and often humorous, but always politically astute. Her content, which includes songs about Wild Garlic, sleep Bees and Mushrooms, is pleasurable and accessible while simultaneously rejecting simplified binaries of "good nature" or "bad humans." She holds complexity with remarkable skill. Nelson routinely cites Black American agrarian histories and Indigenous ecological epistemologies, exposing the

systemic inequities that underpin urban food deserts and green-space segregation, even as she sings in a Kawaii-style falsetto or shares recipes for candying mushrooms. Her videos function not just as tutorials, but as acts of embodied resistance. Even how Nelson *appears* in her videos is part of her political and pedagogical work. In a HuffPost interview, she explained: "I went through a phase where I was urban foraging exclusively wearing dresses with full makeup, because I thought, 'If I look the most palatable version of myself—even if someone doesn't know what I'm doing and the fact that they can't identify it makes them a little bit nervous—hopefully I look so inviting, so pleasant, that they'll come and talk to me about it before they call the cops about it,' which is not an experience that I feel I see a lot of my white counterparts even being a little bit familiar with … I feel like I have to have a speech ready to go at all times, regardless of where I am." (*The Black Forager*, 2024). This is a devastatingly honest glimpse into what it means to forage while being Black in public spaces. Her pink dresses and cheerful demeanour become not just aesthetic choices but strategies of safety—forms of self-protection and permission-granting in a world where Black presence in nature is too often criminalised. Her practice inevitably recalls the case of Christian Cooper, a Black birder falsely accused and threatened in Central Park in 2020 for simply being present and observing birds (Jerkins, 2023).

In contrast to romanticised images of white naturalists, Nelson must constantly negotiate how her body is perceived in predominantly white public spaces. Her visual styling becomes camouflage and armour, allowing her to carry out the joyful labour of foraging under the gaze of a society structured by racial fear and

surveillance. By aestheticising safety and queering the visual codes of environmental labour, Nelson expands who belongs in nature and exposes the socio-political structures that limit that belonging. Her work refuses disembodied "green" discourses and insists that ecological knowledge *must* be understood through race, gender, class, and historical power. For her, a vital component is to entangle this knowledge with human histories of extraction, racialised dispossession, and colonial land management. In the episode "The Awful truth About No Trespass"(2022) Nelson together with co-host Yara Elmjouie dives deep into the reasons why BIPOC people in the US are not out foraging as much as their white counterparts; [Alexis]

"..a lot of the reason why we're not out here in these wild spaces, why we're not all climbing...trees and harvesting...is because historically- systemically- we have been suppressed from doing so." (*The Awful TRUTH About 'No Trespassing' Laws*, 2022, Timecode: 12:52-13:05). Through the video, they pedagogically go through the racialised history of the US and access to land.

In other videos Nelson identifies invasive plants introduced through settler agriculture; *Black Mustard introduced by Spanish missionaries* (Nelson, 2024c), *demonstrates alternative Indigenous foodways; Manoomin wild rice and how it is traditionally harvested/cultivated by Indigenous groups in the US* (Nelson, 2024a) and invites viewers into reciprocal relationships with both humans and non-humans; *in "BEE TONGUES ARE SO CUTE SEND HELP" Alexis helps a bee that has woken up early, due to HICC, enabling it to survive and pollinate (=making futures possible)* (Nelson, 2024b). Her work re-centres land and kin as politically

charged, storied agents, not neutral backdrops to humans. This is vital. White, Rudy and Gareau (2016) warn that unless we couple the "vitality, liveliness and creativity of our material world" with that of the

"lively, vital, potential creativity of situated hybrid humans as world makers… then the result of hybrid work could simply reinforce the neoliberal view that we live in a world largely out of our control" (White, Rudy and Gareau, 2016, p. 142).

Nelson counteracts these "flattening qualities and reductionist dangers." (White, Rudy and Gareau, 2016, p. 142). [Alexis]

"...there's something about the almost gleeful anticipation of the downfall of society that doesn't sit right with my spirit!!"(Nelson, 2024d, Timecode: 00:14-00:27).

Rather than trading one truth or idea for another, she re-embeds ecological experience in situated, relational, historical and political terms. She as a creator offers "transitional infrastructur[e] for the extended meanwhile" (Berlant, quoted in Seigworth *et al.*, 2024, p. 2).

It is also of importance that Nelson does this on digital platforms. She is able to use the short-form, entertainment-oriented media of Instagram and TikTok to distribute meaningful, politicised and loving ecological knowledge to an enormous number of people. In so doing she demonstrates that digital infrastructures can be part of a counter-hegemonic movement by being sites for renewed subject-formation- one where ecological agency is inseparable from

historical accountability and collective world-making. Nelson teaches us that urban foraging is not just about what plants to munch on—it is about learning how to move through landscapes haunted by inequality while still finding Joy, kinship, and care.

5.6 Multispecies Ethnography and Critical Place-Thinking in Nelson's Work

Human geography has always been centred on the 'sense of place', where the "subjective and emotional attachments an individual or group develop toward a particular place, based on …experiences, memories and perceptions…" (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 2). Radically shifting urban landscapes transform culturally significant geography into "placelessness" and "meaningless architectural patterns" (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 2), where the emotional connections between individuals, space, and place begin to disengage from one another. As these sites erode, new alternative ways of interpreting place formation evolve. Through the digital, physical space can exist simultaneously as both "local" and "global", becoming "illusions… Not so much erased as disconnected from their histories, fragmented into a chaotic mix…then reconstructed into networked hybrids…" (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 3). 'This hybrid sense of space' can exist in the "symbiotic interaction[s] between technology, society, locality and stakeholders" (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 3).

Market forces, bureaucratic systems, and digital technologies continuously reshape spatial relations, embedding control into everyday experiences. Algorithms, big data, and virtual reality do more than mediate space—they

structure and govern it, shaping behaviours in ways that must be critically examined rather than taken for granted. The virtual dimension alters our understanding and formation of 'space, place and relations' as our world experience becomes more digital (Dai & Liu, 2024, p. 2). In 2019, the concept of the "digital turn of geography" was coined as a new term to explain how ICT (Information and Communication Technology), globalisation, and modernisation mediate and impact these dynamic interactions. Space/place can, in this sense, endlessly oscillate between the local and global through the openness and connectivity of the internet and digital media. Online forums and social media platforms allow for local and global engagement. By sharing their knowledge, local influencers can help their viewers appreciate and understand their surroundings more, whether they are close or remote from each other. Reconnecting to your surroundings may lead to an added love or respect for where you live and who you share that space with, human or more-than-human. "Stories are doorways to a larger sphere of history" (Stone, E., 2002, p.176).

In the TikTok video *This is me living my lizzie mcguire italian fantasty tbh* (Nelson, 2024h), Alexis is on a trip to Torino, Italy and comes across a very old Roman wall which has plants growing on the sides of it. Rather than focusing on the 2000-year-old "a feat of ancient engineering", Alexis invites us to look closer, to what is inhabiting the cracks on the wall. "Toadflax", "Pellitory on the wall", "Sorrel", and a little plant Alexis refers to as "this little guy", aka Horseweed. This plant, she explains, is not native to Italy, but has travelled all the way from America, which is "a long way away for someone without legs"(Nelson, 2024h, Timecode: 00:35:00- 00:45). Giving the plant its own agency, and its own person,

“She” - or Horseweed is allowed to be part of the story, rather than be the backdrop against which human architecture stands and is triumphant. Nelson’s storying of these new worlds does not ignore the “contradictory truths” of the Anthropocene. Alexis reads the landscape as complex and with a past,

“One of my favourite things to do is read an area through the plants that are present in it, many times that will tell you more than a history book about the people who have come through that area...[The theory is that Horseweed] seeds got stuck in furs [shipped from the US to Europe] and that is how it began colonising these spaces...Reverse colonisation'(Nelson, 2024h, Timecode: 01:10-01:22).

With humour and great pedagogic skill, Alexis teaches us to see and read the landscape anew. Haraway reminds us we must acknowledge the “mortal entanglements between human and non-humans” in order to “ co-flousi[sh] (Haraway, quoted in White, Rudy and Gareau, 2016, pp. 134–135). Nelson actively engages with these opposing perspectives. By allowing them all to have an active part in her storying, Nelsons work can be understood as what White, Rudy and Gareau (2016) describe as

“modes of analysis of our socio-ecological entanglements that build alternative patterns of association, of gathering together the multiple forces that commit to more lively sustainable and fulfilling worlds.” (White, Rudy and Gareau, 2016, p. 137). Horseweed becomes storied kin whom we walk with, rather than walk past.

Through this kind of work, Nelson co-creates new habitats, ecosystems, and worlds (stories) in which we are invited to explore and participate. In these new or *additional* spaces, Nelson—and her audience, or as she playfully calls us/them "children" (*The Awful TRUTH About 'No Trespassing' Laws*, 2022)—can become active participants in what poet Tom Jay describes as *edge ecologies*: "a vibrant brood between the human soul and the natural world" (Stone, 2002, p. 177). Jay's metaphor describes the meeting of two ecosystems, "Ecotones" or "Edge Ecologies". Initially described by Frederic Edward Clements in the early 19th century these are zones of interaction, transformation, and adaptation that emerge at the boundaries of different ecosystems in nature, which often created unique and biodiverse environments, such as a border between a forest and a prairie or a coastline and a river—where

"a border of rich diversity and fertility precipitates between them, a place of increased imagination. The evolved and practised narratives of the two systems mixed in a terminus, a verge of opportunity and peril" (Stone, 2002, p. 177).

Together with Nelson, we are co-creating something new. Blending the digital and the physical, the whimsical, the complex, the beautiful and the painful into possible opportunities for "ruptures" (Jandrić, 2022, p. xiv) where this study hopefully imagines Leonard Cohen's "light can get in"(Cohen, 1992).

"The essence of postdigital culture…stands not for a time after the digital but as an acknowledgement that the materiality of the digital is not reducible to the screen…it is a massively distributed reality that in turn conditions our perceptual realities" (Jandrić, 2022, p. xiv).

5.7 Design Ontologies - Worlds Within Worlds

In Nelson's work, edges and metaphors become a world-making practice that fuses landscapes with imagination and creativity. Through digital storytelling, she transforms everyday details—often unseen or unwanted living beings into rich, sensory landscapes that "bind us to the earth and our lives upon it" (Stone, 2002, p. 177). The *"Marry Me Puffball" video (Nelson, 2024e)* has changed how this author sees, understands, and relates to Puffballs *(big, white,* ball-shaped mushrooms)—and, by extension, to the shared landscape we inhabit. Through her storytelling, Nelson enabled me "to go beyond [myself] toward the world" (Stone, 2002, p. 177). That virtual encounter evolved into a physical one when I later found, picked, and cooked the mushroom myself. What emerged was what Anna Tsing calls "history-in-the-making"[8] (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015). The mushroom and I were now entangled; our meeting transformed me—perhaps it even transformed the mushroom. We created a narrative arc together, one that moves us along in an indeterminable way. Mycologist Alan Rayner says its the indeterminacy of mycelium networks that excite him the most (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015, p. 47). Unlike humans, mushrooms change shape based on their environment and encounters—they are unpredictable in their growth. What if our human indeterminacy were not rooted in our bodies' shape but our motions over time? This would expand our concept of human life, showing us how we are changed through encounter. Foraging is one such

[8] For Anna Tsing the phrase "history in the making" is meant to challenge the popularised idea of history as a clear, linear story of progress. Instead, she shows history as a messy, ongoing process shaped by many different actors and events over time.

encounter. Though we live habitually, encounters with other beings offer moments where new responses and futures become possible. In the *Marry Me Puffball* episode, Nelson jokes about the mushroom and how it's "so good it's gonna make someone get down on one knee and propose" (Nelson, 2024e, Timecode: 00:11-00:17).

As we move through time, we change both ourselves and the landscape. The mushroom needs me to spread its spores; I need the mushroom for sustenance, and Nelson gets a proposal out of it. We collaborate for survival through difference, "creating diversity through contamination" (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015, p. 28). Contamination becomes co-evolution, co-living—a recognition that we are not separate. Tsing calls these sites of friction where species, cultures, and systems collide, negotiate, and transform "assemblages"[9]. These friction sites are always with us, continuously evolving and relational, forming something more-than-human. These sites of friction defy boundaries. Plants, fungi, lichen, and berries grow wherever they are able. Breaking through pavements, thriving in abandoned lots, reclaiming space—these so-called "weeds" are doing scented/tasty/colourful resistance work. Their refusal to abide by static mappings[10] of "nature", exposes the mismatch between dynamic ecosystems and top-down political boundaries. Urban foragers who find, pick,

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[9] These sites are as mentioned *unintentional* spaces, like a forest clearing, a city park edge where unexpected interactions occur.

[10] There are of course many styles of maps, here I am referencing the way humans tend to zone nature in order to make sense of space. For example in cityplanning or zoning maps.

and value them do the same. In Donna Haraway's *Cyborg Manifesto* (1991), digital ecologies are imagined as spaces of resistance and world-making—where Descartian binaries/boundaries like human/nature, physical/virtual, and organic/technological are dissolved by the hybrid, boundary-breaking cyborg (the cyborg as metaphor for identity, knowledge, and the political). Through Haraway's lens, Nelson's digital content is not separate from "real" ecological landscapes, but extensions of them—zones where contamination and transformation occur. This weaving between worlds resists global development frameworks that erase local knowledge and identity (Melber et al., 2024, p. 98). In the episode *Poke Sallat* (Nelson, 2024g), Alexis celebrates the toxic and invasive Pokeweed. In the video, Poke is transformed back into the edible dish that many Black communities used to frequently eat and enjoy as an early spring green in the US. Alexis elevates Poke further, allowing it to become a symbol of resilience and cultural memory. [Alexis eating Poke] "Mmm, tastes like tradition"(Nelson, 2024g, Timecode: 00:51-01:20). Her content becomes a form of resistance: nourishing marginalised histories, challenging colonial hierarchies of knowledge, and weaving together ancestral practice with contemporary digital storytelling. It is a cyborg ecology—rooted, hybrid, and defiantly alive.

These hybrid worlds echo Clements's ecological concept of *Edges* mentioned earlier. In today's damaged world, these "Edges" or zones are not only forest clearings and urban wastelands but also digital spaces where "multispecies entanglements" occur in the ruins of capitalism (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015). "Recuperation is still possible, but only…across the killing divisions of nature,

culture, and technology and of organism, language and machine" (Haraway, 2016, pp. 117–118). Destruction, then, is not an endpoint, but a site of ongoing generative adaptation. Much like how the rare Matsuke mushroom unintentionally flourishes in timbered forest landscapes (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015), alternative foodways, digital foraging, and ecological love can grow in and out of unexpected spaces. These ongoing speculative edge worlds where species, technologies, and ideas collide unpredictably have been named the Chthulucene by Haraway (2016). An alternative to the Anthropocene—the Chutulucene is a place where survival depends on *Sympoiesis*, or the "making-with" (Tsing & Haraway, 2015). Here, humans, algorithms, fungi, plants, and other non-human kin must collaborate and co-create new meanings, new localities, new worlds.

These multispecies entanglements resist capitalist scalability. As Tsing (2015) explains, scalability—the logic of expanding without transformation—demands uniformity and suppresses the unpredictable, relational encounters that constitute life. Capitalist and colonial projects rely on scalability: agricultural monocultures, resource extraction, and standardised systems of control. However, non-scalable systems—such as fungal networks, forests, and grassroots collaborations—thrive on adaptation and contingency. Digital relationships can be understood in similar terms. Online presence is co-constructed—not isolated—through dialogue, storytelling, and mutual shaping, commenting and sharing. Digital storytelling becomes a tool that allows physical and virtual worlds to touch. These intersecting edges offer resistance, connection, and reimagining beyond the racialised and historical constraints of physical landscapes. Digital mobilisation can reconnect

communities with ecological knowledge and foster new relational modes of living. However, we must proceed with care. In *Designs for the Pluriverse*, Escobar (2018) reminds us of the destructive potential of technology. He calls us to move beyond "capitalist industrial instrumentation" (Escobar, 2018, p. 18) and instead cultivate "qualitatively new modes of becoming" through the very artificial means that shape our world. Design, Escobar argues, *is* World-Making—it shapes not only objects but futures. He distinguishes between Broad Transitions (large-scale shifts toward sustainability and justice) and Design for Autonomy (locally grounded, community-led design). The internet can support both, enabling global collaboration and local innovation.

However, both approaches require deep creative resistance to "predatory formations… that generate sustained expulsions… and ecological devastation" (Sassen in Escobar, 2018, p. 222). Tsing (2015) offers one imaginative route:

"We are stuck with the problem of living despite economic and ecological ruination. Neither tales of progress nor tales of ruin tell us how to think about collaborative survival. It is time to pay attention to mushroom picking. Not that this will save us—but it might open our imaginations" (Lowenhaupt-Tsing, 2015, p. 19).

Nelson's work makes us pay attention. Makes us imagine. Lets the light in.

Foraging is territorial, relational, and pluriversal. It supports local knowledge, mutual care, and resilience. Though it demands knowledge and skill, it is a horizontal practice accessible outside institutional systems. Urban foraging

disrupts the binaries of nature/human, culture/nature, and human/non-human. It centres *being* over *doing*, in a process of co-creation with land, history, and multispecies communities. It invites a shift from development defined by growth or success toward more relational, ecological ways of becoming. Nelson embodies a kind of digital and ecological World-Making that aligns with Pluriversal designs. Her foraging practice, shared through joyful and accessible digital storytelling, resists extractive systems by centring relational knowledge, embodied skill, and care for place. Rather than offering progress narratives, her work invites imaginative, grounded survival, rooted in botanical know-how, ancestral wisdom and urban ecologies. It is design for autonomy: community-driven, outside institutional frameworks, and oriented toward mutual flourishing. "One of the ways I take care of one of my communities, you guys, is teaching you free food that you can find out in the wild" (Nelson, 2024d, Timecode: 00:14-00:27). By blending digital platforms with local, multispecies relationships, Nelson enacts a creative, resistant mode of becoming—one that nourishes connection in the ruins of the Anthropocene, one that makes kin in the Chthulucene.

Escobar argues for alternative ontologies of development: ones that reject capitalist linearity and anthropocentrism. He imagines a living cosmos—one brought forth *together*.

"We have only the world that we bring forth with others, and only love helps us bring it forth" (Escobar, 2018, p. 83). Ursula Le Guin reminds us, "The trouble is we've all let ourselves become part of the killer story, and so we may get finished

along with it. Hence, it is with a certain feeling of urgency that I seek the nature, subject, words of the other story, the untold one, the life story" (Le Guin quoted, Haraway, 2016, p. 119).

This life story is retold, time and time again, by Nelson, as she forages, gathers and collects plants, recipes, and stories for new worlds possible. Kimmerer (2013) says,

"We are all bound by a covenant of reciprocity…Water knows this, clouds know this. Soul and rocks know they are dancing in a continuous giveaway of making, unmaking and making again the earth. (Wall Kimmerer, 2015, p. 383).

All we have to do is open our eyes, to each other, to the landscapes we walk in and the beauty of the worlds we stand in.

6. Conclusion

Haraway asks in her book, *Staying with the Trouble. Making Kin in the Chthulucene* (2016),

"…how do we take back up a collective adventure that is multiple and ceaselessly reinvented, not on an individual basis, but in a way that passes the baton, that is to say, affirms new givens and new unknowns?" (Haraway, 2016, p. 130).

In response, this author looks to Alexis Nikole Nelson and Joyfully exclaims, "Like this!" 😀

Nelson's digital storytelling and ecological praxis operate as Speculative Ecological World-Making—relational, future-oriented, and rooted in land,

history, and community. Her work aligns with Speculative Ecofeminism by resisting linear, extractive narratives of nature and progress, investing instead in intimacy, nourishment, and joy, much like Le Guin's carrier bag theory and Kimmerer's ethic of reciprocity. Rather than engaging in utopian abstraction, Nelson enacts possibility through embodied storytelling and grounded pedagogy, inviting collective imagination and co-creation. Foraging, for Nelson, is an entangled practice—emerging through multispecies relationships with plants, fungi, people, and places across both physical and digital terrains. In line with what Tsing (2015) refers to as the 'art of noticing', Nelson finds, in the cracks of pavements, overlooked, forgotten kin *with* which she co-creates futures from the edges. This relational sensibility aligns with Multispecies Ethnography, which centres on the interconnected lives and agencies of diverse beings within shared worlds.

Her approach also reflects Critical Place-Thinking, as it challenges colonial notions of land as 'terra nullius', meaning vacant, empty, or pristine. In Nelson's content, all space—a sidewalk, a forest or her backyard—is storied, sacred, and pedagogical, embodying the idea that "land is pedagogy" (Simpson, 2014). Here, pedagogy recognises knowledge as emerging from relationships, rather than coming from institutional authorities. Nelson's online content enacts this by allowing foraging and direct interaction with plants to be joyful, living forms of ecological learning that invite participatory, decolonial learning outside traditional systems.

Through urban foraging, she cultivates accessible, Joyful, and embodied learning rooted in place. This also aligns Nelson's work with Decolonial Ecological Thought, which reclaims space for Black and Indigenous knowledge through a praxis of reciprocity, ancestral memory, and joyful resistance. Her work becomes a form of Ontological Design, one of many world-making practices that form the Pluriverse (Escobar, 2018).

Nelson uses her platforms and voice to inform, perform and enact alternative ways of being that are speculative, situated, deeply loving and Joyful. In doing so, she disrupts dominant environmental narratives shaped by whiteness and settler colonialism, consumerism and capitalism. She is not interested in the Hero's Journey. For her, the stories worth gathering and sharing are affective ecologies of thriving, Joy, and relationships.

Storytelling, as foraging, has been and is central to the human experience. We have many stories, many storytellers—but Alexis Nikole Nelson is different. She pulls you in with the surface details—plants, recipes, weeds—and suddenly, you find yourself learning about colonialism, history, and community care while contemplating how to deep-fry a dandelion. That is powerful social justice pedagogy. Her huge online following shows the success of her approach in a space where stories fight for attention, amplification, and return. Communication for development (ComDev) has always been in the business of storytelling: of levelling up, visualising change, and determining who gets what. However, it also needs *futuring* stories that offer complex, plural unfoldings. Stories that exist in the present can hold the past, and imagines possible futures.

Nelson's digital carrier bag is not just filled with recipes but with Other Worlds. Her work reaches through space and time, intertwining ancient collective survival strategies: Storytelling & wild food foraging into possible new ways of being in the future. Her hybrid, cyborg character co-creates, through the digital, new edge ecologies where different multispecies assemblages are possible. Where a future, not as a resurrection of a romanticised past but as a "tentacular multi-temporal, multi-spacial past, present and yet to come…an undecided temporality" (Haraway, 2015) can be imagined. To be drawn in is also to act—I cannot help myself. The world looks different, and I want to explore it/eat it/and make kin with it.

Nelson is Co-Making-With. She is moving beyond The Great Dithering and is choosing instead Sympoiesis, that "carrier bag for ongoingness, [that] yoke for becoming-with, for staying with the trouble of inheriting the damages and achievements of colonial and postcolonial naturalcultural histories in telling the tale of still possible recuperation" (Haraway, 2016, p. 125) and is reaching her hand out, inviting us to join her. And we are. By the millions.

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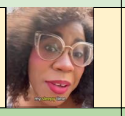
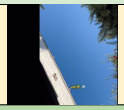
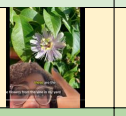
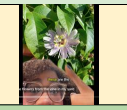
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Appendices

Blackforager Coding Template

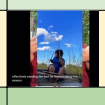
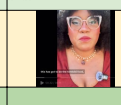
CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
1	This is me living my lizzie mcguire italian fantasy tbh	Alexis identifies Homewood in Torino, Italy and discusses how it has come from the US through 'reverse colonialism', how it is seen as 'useful' to Indigenous people but a 'scourge' to US and Eu farmers, and how to read the landscape based on the plants that grow there- and how that is a way of understanding the land in a richer and deeper way than history books.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, More-than-human Agency, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making	Nelson uses humor and casual tone; her camera work is playful, hand held and 'low fi'; she speaks about ancestral knowledge, and colonialism both in the modern and old world and how they are interrelated; how 'comprehensively globalised our world has become' Nelson teaches ways of seeing and reading the land, space and place based on kin species (plants) around her -opening up new possible ways to see the world.	The video centres joyful, embodied ecological practice rooted in ancestral knowledge, she 'sees' others (plants) where before it was 'just plants on the wall' and tells their story. She allows other to have agency, and sees the plant - and brings importance to 'her' over the 2000 year old wall she is growing on. sees beyond the human built landscape.	The plant is personified and addressed as kin; shown as an active participant in the story. Homewood is given agency, referred to as 'this little guy' and 'he's from where I'm from... a long way for a someone with no legs and 'this sweet little bean'	Highlights overlooked urban green space and layers of colonial and ecological history. Example- "One of my favourite things to do is read an area through the plants that are present in it, a lot of times that will tell you more than a history book about the people who have come through that area...[the theory is that Homewood] seeds got stuck in furs [shipped from the US to Europe] and that is how it got to begin colonising these spaces... 'Reverse colonisation'	Connects foraging to Black ancestral wisdom and food autonomy; disrupts dominant food norms. Although she gives the 'official' botanical name for the plant she also talks about how it is considered pesky/a weed. Ex. "this sweet little bean is Homewood otherwise known as Erigeron canadensis or Conyza canadensis, she keeps flip flopping geniuses. But she's delicious and a pretty powerful astringent. The Navajo still have a practice today of making tea with Homewood leaves and applying that to pimples and other skin breakouts"	Nelson opens up new worlds where humans can begin to interact with their surroundings in new and imaginative ways. Example- "Have you visited with your plants recently? Have you asked them what they have to tell? The filming also adds to this feeling of connection- as it is so rough and ready, Nelson touches the plants and zooms in and out, overlays images through-out, it is hard as a viewer to not be drawn in and almost feel like she is talking to you and inviting you in to also experience what she is experiencing.	https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7147236521095172586
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	VISUAL									

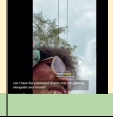
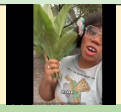
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2	The awful TRUTH about "No Trespassing" laws	This is an Emmy Award-winning short documentary with expert Ronger Alexis Wilcoks Nelson (aka @blackforager) and AJ- host Yara Elmjouie. In the clip Yara follows Alexis around in Ohio and learns about the edible plants in the neighborhood, how to cook them and also about how alexis came to be the BlackForager and why it is important to be her in such a 'white space' as foraging in the US and then the video dives deeper into the No Trespass laws in the United States and how they relate to slavery, racism and colonialism.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Nelson and Yara use humor and casual tone throughout the video which makes it easier to take in and understand the content which at times is very sad and painful. The whole editing of the video makes it quick paced and it uses overlayed media and graphics to add personality and fun. There are multiple ways in which the audience can engage with the content, learning to see place and space in new ways, understanding how racism is relayed to foraging and outdoor activities in the US as well as pedagogical cooking tips on how to eat foraged foods. It manages to pack in an awful lot of information in a very accessible way.	1) Alexis embodies care when she asks- " a little afraid of going to the grocery store right now? That's OK! I'm going to show you some things that are growing in your neighborhood that you can eat... the next day...[that video] had like thousands of views and I was like what?! The children [a comic and caring reference to her audience] like kann? I can give them plants! 2) Alexis and Yara go home and cook(all the food they cooked -)'Yara in an excited tone) "this is amazing! We just found all this food in the wild!" (Alexis) Foraging and being more connected to place, to your present, to your past, by means of food...it's magical!" (Yara overlay)" everything we were eating, we'd gathered that day in the wild, for free. From a park, from a forest, and yes even a sidewalk..[and it was] what all this meant and the context we were doing it in. [Alexis] for me to do this act [foraging] and have no one besides me benefiting from it, it just feels like giving a middle finger to this system that was inherently created to put us at a disadvantage...in this way foraging as a Black person is an act of rebellion"	Alexis is arguing for the foraging of certain invasive species (Curly Dock) in the park -" a really great thing, about this is, because they have a pretty invasive habit you are doing your native plant friends a favour". In this way she is showing how other species, native plants in this example, can benefit from our foraging and being in nature. We become a POSITIVE force and ally for native plants and is an encouragement to go out and be an active participant in nature. Humans are not just destructive, but we form part of an ecosystem where other plants can benefit from us.	1) Talks about how free food is everywhere- to 're-learn a place." -...together with Alexis we discover a hidden world of 'free, wild foods growing within our cities....this is just a weed, growing out of the sidewalk and it can be the heck out of your dishes at home", 2) Talks about the history of No Trespass Laws in America- "these laws were specifically designed...to stop people who looked like Alexis from foraging, where black people lived the law changed [after emancipation] to hang them."	1) Alexis highlights a Cornelian Cherry tree and educates her audience "...those of you who are familiar with Middle Eastern cuisine are probably much more familiar with [it] (as this Yara throws his hands in the air with joy as he is from Iran). he turns to the camera and says "in Iran we call them 'Zaghal Akteh'." By doing this Alexis is embracing other cultures and other namings of plants besides the latin or english references most commonly used online. She is being inclusive and interested, open to learning. 2) Alexis talks about her work and about being black and the history of losing ecological knowledge due to systematic oppression - "there is a reason why there's not a lot of people who look like me who are doing this [foraging] and I am trying very hard to change that narrative now... BlackForager is what I go by, and I often get the question why? Why do you need to bring race into [foraging]?... I didn't see a lot of people who looked like me in, the modern-day foraging space... so this day, here in the United States...it's still a very predominately white hobby...and the storied history with Black people, Indigenous people, poor people and their access to land and...food..." 3) (Alexis) "...a lot of the reason [we are not here is that we] were...when we ran	Alexis is sharing some plant knowledge with the host [aja about an edible in a park and making us aware of other possible ways of seeing and understanding where we live, new worlds to explore- "it's super gingery but also a little floral and so many people pass it...and have no clue they're just walking right on by this, like, powerhouse of flavour and smell" and the aditi comically enhances the joy and amusement of [a]a as it has a transported almost by the smell to a different dimension. 2) Alexis and [a]a are walking along the urban streets of Ohio and finding plants to forage in a seemingly 'dead' sidewalk. " Ah! Purslane! (Alexis sings) and it's full of nutrition....edible things can sometimes be growing out of the pavements! (overlay of an arrow and the text Edible thing).	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Pdmc1f2Bvs
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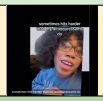
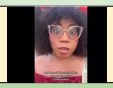
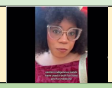
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3	Exploring Passiflora Incarnata: The Known Plant	TikTok	Nelson identifies the Maypop Passionfruit.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	In this video Alexis goes through another TikTok Trik video where she explains how one fruit , the Maypop Passionfruit, is actually edible. She wants to encourage people to dare to learn about new plants and if they are edible. She discussed Indigenous use of the plant and how it's good for local pollinators as well as also mentioning how Climate Change is enfanging its habitat.	In the video Alexis is trying to show how children might be smarter than their parents think, and that it is a good thing to be inquisitive and interested in your surroundings. She is also vulnerable, sharing how she uses the Plant in her sleep time tea as it has anxiety reducing abilities. By sharing this her hears that she suffers occasionally from anxiety, and offers a free solution for others who might also have anxiety. She could here shared the plants medicinal uses without sharing her personal issues, but she chooses to be vulnerable in this way, which creates a feeling of trust and caring.	Alexis films the sky and makes a crow sound(I'm visiting California, always nice to say hi to the locals)points to the sky implying she is speaking to the bird(than just flew by.) By doing this she is relating to all the beings around her, not just people,or even plants, but also giving agency and importance to all creatures around her- making them kin, a community which is multispecies.	The Maypop goes from being an unidentified plant in the beginning, to a flower worth having in your yard for bees to a historically important plant used for medicine. This way of storytelling creates value around the plant in many dimensions.	In the clip we learn how the plant has been used by Indigenous People for ages. The plant becomes more than a beautiful thing to look at, but that it has historic practical benefits.	In the clip Alexis is creating space in which children's curiosity isn't dangerous or silly, rather Alexis is proving that kids know more than parents often imagine, where there is space for inquisitiveness, imagination and interaction with nature which isn't controlled or designed by the adult. [Alexis] Let me tell you why your daughter might be smarter than you think. [Alexis then casts the fruit open, asking for guesses as to what the fruit is] ...this is a Maypop passionfruit, [Alexis bites into it] mmm so sweet...so while I think it's good to encourage your daughter...to not eat a plant unless they know what it is maybe your daughter knew what it was [Alexis smiles into	https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7440220561193468624?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
4	Movin Me Puffball mushroom tatdie ____	Nelson stumbles upon a whole lot of Puffballs, and goes on to pick, prepare and cook them, making it so delicious that her fiance proposes again.	Food as Pedagogy, Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability, Urban Ecologies and Contamination	The video is a funny and pedagogic video where Nelson teaches you how to prepare and eat Puffballs.			The Puffball mushroom becomes an agent of change in the video, where its delicious flesh creates feelings so strong that people are willing to propose. Taken beyond the joker tone, Nelson way of storytelling in this clip could be understood as working on the "prostilagnetic level...[where] storytelling rewards and remodels subject-object relations in ways that subtly alter the balance between actor and actud upon." (Jackson, 2002, p.56) . Nelson and the Puffballs also consumtimes each other as they are forever changed after the encounter- Nelson is proposed to yet again and the Puffball has been elevated to Match Maker.		"stories are always structured in-between...[they] create indeterminate and ambiguous situations that involve contending parties, contrasting locations, opposing categories of thought and antithetical domains of experience...they transgress." (Jackson, 2002, p.17-18). Nelsons Puffball recipe is a way for her to show her users that they/she can get what they want, "securing some future advantage" (in this case a marriage proposal). "Getting what you want very often means getting the right story" Jackson, 2002, p. 26)	https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7145056573484624742?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
5	PLACE YER BETS? Here magic will be found!	Nelson proves that free food is everywhere by biking in her neighbourhood and identifying plants along the way	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	This video is casual and funny, hand held footage but is about how to see the landscape differently.	Nelson take us on a seemingly funny bike ride around her neighbourhood, showing us edible and medicinal plants as she goes, with her camera crash down her bikini. However, the underlying care for and willingness to share her knowledge in order to make her audience see free food all around them is a profound example of ecofeminism in practice. The lighheartedness of the video does not remove from the community building she is partaking in.	Nelson stops biking and films a new, local bridge which has "bird shacks" incorporated into it. We are seeing how the architecture in the city is creating spaces for other beings in it, and Nelson is noticing this together with us.	"That's Columbus the city, not the Colonizer"- Nelson comments when talking about how much she loves her city. Although funny the comment is momentarily jarring, cognitively awakening her audience that her content, storytelling abilities are working on multiple dimensions, funny, pedagogical and profoundly steaped in history	"That's Columbus the city, not the Colonizer"- Nelson comments when talking about how much she loves her city. Although funny the comment is momentarily jarring, cognitively awakening her audience that her content, storytelling abilities are working on multiple dimensions, funny, pedagogical and profoundly steaped in history		https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7197090634108806663?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
6	Harvesting Wild Rice-A Priest-Deloney Revealed	Nelson teaches us about Manoomin- wild rice.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	A lot of editing between Nelson herself, overlaid images and the ricing method she learns. It is edited to feel fast paced yet easy to follow.	With a lot of detail Nelson pedagogically teaches the viewers how to 'rice'		"upon given a prophecy to leave the North East and go to a place where food grew on the water, got to the Great Lakes and were like this has got to be the foretold food". Nelson allows us to understand the historic and cultural importance of Manoomin for the Anishinaabe and Dakota tribes.	"Ricing is an example of indigenous agricultural science" - in the video Nelson teaches us the Indigenous history of Manoomin, or Wild rice in the US, giving her viewer an insight into the work that goes into it, it's historic importance and why it's so expensive.	Nelson imagines her African and Indigenous descendants sweating and sharing their knowledge of ricing as a way to foster a friendship or camaraderie in the face of white colonialism and brutal oppression. She allows her audience to see her gut emotional, vulnerable and sad which creates a deeper sense of connection to her and the video. She is emotionally describing potential meetings in the past, potential relationships and mutual caring.	https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7413505570503162762?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
7	POKE SALLET / SALLIT / SALAD - a dish that shows up in indigenous, afr...	Poke Sallat preparation	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Hand held, close ups of Nelson in her neighborhood. It feels natural and real which aligns well with the subject matter.	Although toxic when mature, Nelson teaches her viewers how to prepare Poke so that it is rendered harmless and edible. Nelson points out that Poke used to be eaten a lot in the past, and by cooking it in front of her audience, she is teaching lost knowledge. Nelson also interacts with her neighbour in order to pick some Poke growing in their yard, asking for permission and being vulnerable- creating and participating in community.			Nelson describes how many Black, poor, Indigenous and rural communities harvested Poke as the first spring green and that she remembers her grandparents mentioning Poke to her as a child.		https://www.tiktok.com/@alexisbjuke/video/7364586399161852030?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
8	Black Mustard Seeds: History, Legends, and Uses	We learn about Black Mustard and its colonial past.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy , Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Edits between Nelson in a pink and fluffy outfit and a person violently breaking plants work well in this pedagogic video. The going between help balance out the hard topic.	Jackson (2002) notes that "storytelling...provides strategies and generated] experiences that help people redress imbalances and correct perceived injustices in the distribution of Being, so that in telling a story with others one reclaims some sense of agency;" (Jackson, 2002, p.36). In the video Nelson is dressed in vivid pink and feathers, and cuts between herself and another person's clip where they are smashing mustard plants to the ground violently. Nelsons outfit feels designed to help 'soften' her appearance as she explains the dark past of the yellow flower. It's like she wants to create a sense of safety, where she is harmless and innocuous so that the information about the Mustard plant can be taken more easily. Her clothes are helping the story along, making it possible to redress the imbalance and injustices of the weeds she is uttering, allowing the violence in the other clip to be understandable.		Nelson asks us to critically read a landscape based on the evidence of historic oppression that the plants themselves are proof of. "When Spanish missionaries moved to California, they brought a lot of things with them. Religion that no one was asking for. Diseases that no one was asking for, and also probably black mustard." We understand how the landscape is contaminated with oppressive force and injustice. Through her video we are now also contaminated, the mustard plant now having a complex storied history we cannot forget.			https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7351858243128631414?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
9	Hmmmmmm you gotta see the small turtle pics ___ and dunes a bit of...	Nelson greets spring and her newly awoken friends in the local park	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Close up shots of Nelson herself and of the flies she meets on her walk. Naturalistic in tone.	In this video Nelson is giving us insights into how she feels better when engaging with nature, and how this "sometimes bit harder than my antidepressants do". Sharing in a vulnerable way how nature helps with her wellbeing is a form of community care.	A) "the painted turtles are awake! Happy New Year babies!", B) "I think one of the things that is good for you is visiting with your non human neighbours, like acknowledging all the amazing beings around you", Nelson is actively encouraging her audience to see beyond the human world and invites us to engage with the natural world and the other non-human kin that we share our world with. For her it forms part of staying mentally healthy and happy.	Highlights overlooked creatures and plants which if noticed could be beneficial in a number of ways.			https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7348077995731782961?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
10	Let's learn about a new fruit! ___	This clip was made shortly after the last US election results in 2024, in this clip Nelson is reminding us how community is vital. She talks about how she is looking out for this community the zoffice-sine] by teaching us what wild foods are edible.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	The score used in the video is a low piano melody, adding an additional layer of sadness to the clip. Nelson alternates between being sad and cheery in the video but the music stays the same. We can't escape the tone she sets.	Alexis : "You know another things I realized that bothers me about preppers is they are just like 'I have to be able to do everything myself'. No fam, you don't. Like that's what community is for...if everything fell apart tomorrow I hope my neighbourhood knows I have their back)regardless of who they voted for). "One of the most profound - even damaging - consequences of the rationalistic tradition is the belief in the individual...throughout the centuries... economic and political projects....have carried with them the Trojan horse of the individual, destroying communal and place based forms of relating" (Estera & Prakash quated in Escobar, 2018, p.83) In this clip Nelson reminds us that in troubled times we need to stick together and nurture each other.			The Nannyberry uses over time is explained and we learn how Indigenous bands in the US used it for medicinal purposes. She places the Berry in context historically, embedding it in human culture.	"I teach you about all the wonderful free food hiding around you in plain sight but not in a prepper way... Because There is something about the almost gleeful anticipation of the downfall of society that doesn't sit right with my spirit!" Nelson is reminding you that another way is possible, she is rejecting doomsday projections and brings you back in a place where things are possible. Escobar (2018) says : "In these geographies of destruction...we need to pair with our most optimistic readings of human agency, lest our analysis end up contributing to more of the same or worse, widening the space of the unpelled." Escobar, 2018, p. 222.	https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7348148050217594645?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
11	Where to Find Me When You Need Me	Nelson needs her non-human kin to help her get through the results of the US election.	Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Dressed in bright yellow and hand held camera, Nelson hugs, licks, touches and lies down in nature as a coping measure		In the clip Nelson let's us know that "reaching grass isn't enough, I need to nap on moss..feel a friend...hug a tree...become a shrub." Although comical, it is a gentle reminder that nature and relating to nature is a great coping mechanism. In her comments people respond: "I too need a frond" (KeithAnderson798, "This absolutely, call me in 4 years, I'll be with the roses" (user4328979138965), "I've never resonated with a sentence more than 'I need to become a shrub' (Kaira) The clip sees Nelson wandering around a forest interacting with nature in ways which go from 'normal' - like crunching leaves underfoot to licking a lichen and finally turning herself into a shrub. Her		Nelson is relating to and being with nature in ways which go from normal to radical, she walks over leaves, then hugs a tree and finally transforms into a shrub, which ends the clip. This leads the viewer to believe that this final transformation is what she longed for/ needed. The result(s) Nelson inhabits allows for the magical, the whimsical the impossible.	https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7413384828055276034614?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
12	POISON OR SNACK? (GROUNDCOVER EDITION)	a short video where Nelson teaches us about 2 plants, one a snack and one a poisonous look-a-like. Nelson makes quite a few of these clips, they are funny and accessible pedagogic videos to help her audience identify plants easier.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Singing, dogma style camera filming. Nelson sings and laughs a lot adding to the lightness. This is a good strategy for pedagogic learning, her singing creates easy to remember rules	In this video Nelson helps us identify an edible plant from a look-a-like which is poisonous. [Singing] "one of this is poison and one is a snack, which one are you choosing, A or B? This or that?"	The video has a simple message- how to identify an edible from a poisonous look-a-like. Nelson builds landscapes from the existing one, adding layers of understanding in each video she makes. Her surroundings become participants, some which you can see, some which you can't but they are all there, in person, and have meaning, importance and personality.	Nelson allows us to see the landscape differently, so that you don't walk through it with ignorance but with knowledge. She empowers each of us to skillfully navigate our surroundings with new eyes.			https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7363850325437872662?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
13	Bee-Tempest: A Sweet Surprise in Nature	Nelson hangs out with a bee who has woken up to early	Aesthetic World-Making, Joy & Vulnerability Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Close up shots of Nelson and the bee. Nelson is in a dress and flowers in her hair and has wings on, adding to the feeling of magical realism that this clip is giving off.	[Alexis wearing a fairy outfit with wings holding a sleep bee in her hand] "Do you think because of the wings he thinks I'm a big bee?". The bee in the clip is it's own person and Nelson is relating to "him" and helping him survive the "unseasonably warm weather". She shows caring for other kin, empathy and love for others around her, even the smallest critters. When talking about love and gardens Kimmerer (2018) says ' we are linked in a co-evolutionary circle. The sweeter the peach, the more frequently we disperse its seeds... food plants and people act as selective forces on each other's evolution - the thriving of on in the best interest of the other. To me this sounds a bit like love'. (Kimmerer, 2013, p 124)					https://www.tiktok.com/@ideasincubate/video/7341577930880656086?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
14	Avoiding Spikes: How to Gather Prickly Pears Safely	**Nelson shows us how to gather, prepare and eat Prickly pears.**	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Joy, Urban Ecologies / Contamination	Camera angles vary, close ups to wide. Some visual effects are used and there is a zoom to highlight the joyful and fun in the video.	In the clip we are taught by Nelson how to safely forage and prepare Prickly Pears. She shares a fruit with a couple who walk past, and decides at the end of the clip to leave the found of palm she has been using to the next person "I'm just gonna go ahead and leave magic broom for whomever needs it next". Nelson is sharing her skills and tools with the community, passing it on.	Nelson acknowledges a Squirrel during filming, calling them "friend" who is also enjoying the Pears, thus becoming an active participant in the clip, not a backdrop.		Nelson explains that one of the processes she is using to remove spikes is one she has learnt from some of her Indigenous friends. In a singing voice she exclaims joyfully "Indigenous science wins again".	At the end of the clip Nelson changes into a dress that more lines up with her "fairy godmother" vibe, and there is a feeling of Disneyfication here which brings another layer of meaning and imagination to the video. The final dish is presented by Nelson happily twirling in a hooped skirt and it feels very magical and fun.	https://www.tiktok.com/@ahwiyokohs/video/7103041392943892963?lang=en
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CLIP NR	VIDEO TITLE	DESCRIPTION OF CLIP	THEMATIC CODING	VISUAL STRATEGIES	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: SPECULATIVE ECOFEMINISM	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: MULTISPECIES ETHNOGRAPHY	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: CRITICAL PLACE THINKING	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DECOLONIAL ECOLOGICAL THOUGHT	CRITICAL INTERPRETATION: DESIGN ONTOLOGIES	LINK
15	**HE'S MAD I CALL MYSELF 'BLACK FORAGER' - YouTube**	Nelson responds to a comment about race and how it relates to foraging.	Ancestral & Indigenous Knowledge, Food as Pedagogy and Aesthetic World-Making, Vulnerability	Here Nelson chooses to mainly stay on her own face in close up, it feels like it is a private conversation with her audience.	Nelson is committed to opening up and talking about difficult and complex issues around race. This is important community work. Although hard to discuss, Nelson values honesty and knowledge over ignorance.		"Everything that you eat has a story that you are the final chapter of...one of the things I love most about foraging is that when you are responsible for how something ends up on your plate you start thinking about who else is responsible... I get that acknowledging the whole history of something is sometimes uncomfortable but that doesn't mean that it's wrong so I will keep talking about race and I will keep talking about socioeconomic status and the way that it relates to food..." Nelson pedagogically explains how what we eat has wide implications beyond your plate. Who makes it, who benefits from it. She examines and elucidates the power structures surrounding what you put on your plate and how they have both cultural, historic and political context. She explains how race plays a big role in food production, historically as well as today. Nelson describes foraging a practice that allows for contemplation, in your own time and in your own ways, on how these systems shape our values, concepts and realities about food, culture and sustenance.		Nelson articulates her frustration at the commenter and his ignorance but as well as this she also uses it as a starting point for her lesson in why race matters within food production. With humour and wit she manages to turn something which was mainly nasty and clueless into a pedagogic and open lesson. Her words create space, builds discomfort and humorously flattens the reproach. In doing so Nelson also cracks open closed or confined spaces, airing the laundry and this is really important work. We cannot address the present without knowing, and more importantly feeling the past. She gives us words, stories and loving trust, and in that new worlds bubble to the surface.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fxiaeIsuFuw
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